

Dionysia, or The Orphic Ramayana

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Dionysia, or The Orphic Ramayana

by [Nintinugga](#)

Summary

Dionysia is the Ramayana reflected as Orphic or Pythagorean scripture. The Universal Spirit, conceptualised as Dionysos in the Orphic religion, enters the world as Rama, Prince of Ayodhya. His destiny and purpose in incarnating is to destroy Ravana of Lanka, the Second Pentheus.

Both Rama and Ravana are inexorably pulled towards one another, and towards their Fate. Rama realizes his divinity, loses his humanity to the god Whose incarnation he is; while Ravana undergoes a descent into madness and frenzy which mirrors that of Pentheus in the Bacchae. Sita, meanwhile, is the thread which binds them together, the Instrument of Fate.

Dionysia is a reading of the Ramayana through the lens of Euripides. It is my answer to Valmiki, my explanation of how I read his text and why I do not always agree with what he says.

The only answer worthy of Valmiki is a complete rewrite of his Epic. My source texts are wonders of the ancient world; I can only hope to do them justice.

Dionysos comes to India

Dionysia or The Orphic Ramayana

To Euripides and Valmiki, masters of tragedy and horror

The god came kindly at first to Thebes, saying, "Bring me all the wildness in your hearts; I understand it, it is my Kingdom. My gift is the lesser madness which will rest your souls and save you from the greater. Know yourselves, as my brother Apollo tells you. You have need of me."

*But the Theban women answered, "How dare you! Would you make wild beasts of us? We have laws, and live in the city. You are not worthy of us."
That is why they have the madness of the god without his blessing, and run on the mountains tearing wolves with their teeth.*

Yet it is not Dionysos who, by himself, has devised the game like a cruel child. It takes two to play. The god is that which is. If we will not know him, it is we who make the ironies the Immortals laugh at.

- Mary Renault, The Mask of Apollo

Dionysos comes to India

Poets have sung of Dionysos, god of birth and death and the Underworld, and how he made war on the kings of India. They have written of his army of maenads, wild things from the forest.

They are only half right.

Long ago, in the earliest Age of the Universe, there were only the Titans. Born of Night and Chaos, the Titans were powerful; but they were only physical, disordered Nature. When Zeus was born and saved from the hunger of Kronos his father, Order began in the Universe, and Law was first applied. Zeus fought the Titans in a great war between Chaos and Order; and the Titans were defeated, until only a handful of those great Beings remained, hidden in the flames atop Mount Ida.

But Zeus, he who would impose Order upon the Universe, became a slave to Chaos himself. Struck with a mad love at the sight of Persephone, all alone in the darkness of Hades, Zeus took her and begat a son: Zagreus, the Universal Spirit incarnated into the world, greater than any Titan or Olympian.

Hera, incensed at both her husband's infidelity and the threat Zagreus posed to her station, went down into the lands of the Phrygians in the guise of an old woman. Now the infant Zagreus knew nothing yet of the ways of the world or of the gods. He ran to Hera, saying, "Grandmother, grandmother, have you brought anything for me?" And Hera answered, "Come to my cottage atop the hill, little one, and I'll show you wonderful things!"

Hera led Zagreus to the top of Mount Ida, into the cave of the Titans. There the goddess, who has the power to drive men mad, cast her madness upon the Titans; and in a frenzy, they tore young Zagreus limb from limb and ate his flesh.

The earth shook and the heavens trembled when the Titans took their first bite of Zagreus' torn limbs. Ash darkened the skies, the sea rose up in a gigantic wave, and even Poseidon Earth-Shaker himself hid under the sea in fear. But the Titans never knew it. Enraptured they were in their taste of Zagreus' flesh, for in consuming the Universal, those earthly Beings became one with Heaven. They kept on eating until all but Zagreus' heart had been consumed. As they greedily reached for the still-beating heart of the god, a thunderbolt struck the top of that mountain, burning all the Titans to ashes that scattered in the wind.

From those ashes was born mankind; and this is why we possess both an earthly and a heavenly nature. But the Universal Spirit Who had been Zagreus was undefeated. Determined to come into the world, He entered the womb of the nymph Semele and was reborn as Dionysos Bromius. Fearing Hera's wrath, Zeus told Semele to send her child to Arcadia, to be raised among the shepherds, and to hide his divinity.

Many years young Dionysos lived in Arcadia, unaware even of his own divinity. He played with the shepherdesses in that idyllic land, stole butter from the peasants, and learned the art of mead-making from the Queen of the Bees. Silenus the satyr taught him to sing, and Pan, god of all wild things, taught him the arts of the flute and the lyre.

But Time and Change come even to Arcadia. Chancing upon a wild grapevine, Dionysos instinctively recognized its potential. Picking the grapes and pressing them, he made the world's first wine. Gracious Dionysos shared his creation with all the shepherds on the hillside. All who drank from this wine attained union with the Ultimate, as the Titans had all those years ago; and Dionysos' own divine nature was revealed, as he told the ecstatic shepherds all the Sacred Mysteries of the time before the world was made. And thus was the first Dionysia celebrated.

The news that a god had come among men spread quickly across the land. Men and women came, from Thrace and Argolis and Ionia and even as far as Egypt, to taste Dionysos' wine and to gain divine union in his presence. Dionysos then was irresistible; a mere glance from him drove men and women mad with love, so that they forgot themselves and knew only the god. Soon, Dionysos had a vast army, made not of warriors, but of lovers.

Now Dionysos was of a very different and higher sort of divinity than the Olympians, and he and they both knew it. Europe would not hold both of them. The god could easily have destroyed the Olympians; but in his mercy, he chose a different path. Dancing in ecstasy, Dionysos turned towards the rising sun, his maenad lovers following his path.

On and on they went, crossing rivers and mountains and deserts and plains, sharing the sacrament of wine wherever they came. Dionysos brought joy and love to every place he touched, and the army of maenads grew and grew.

One day, after crossing a mighty frozen desert, Dionysos and his maenads found themselves facing a range of black mountains like a wall at the edge of the world; mountains taller than any they had seen, their pinnacles hidden among the clouds. In that wall was but a single door: a single pass high upon the icy mountainside. But maenads feel no cold, no pain. They rushed up the black mountains singing, following Dionysos who danced before them. Only the gods know how many maenads died that day, and whether their ghosts ever made the journey across the Styx.

But at the top of the pass, all sorrows were forgotten. Above the clouds, the sun shone bright and golden, and a field of gossamer clouds stretched out before the maenads. The army danced and sang and drank the last of their wine in a great Dionysia at the summit; for no grapevines grew in the barren lands they had passed through.

When the next day dawned and the maenads had drunk all their wine, they descended from the pass into a land of great rivers and lush green fields whose bounty not even Arcadia could match. Here Dionysos taught his maenads the proper cultivation of the vine: how to graft and prune, when to harvest and press, so that they need not depend on only wild vines any longer. And the god established there his Kingdom upon the earth; and man, woman, and beast lived in peace and joy.

But Death comes to all, and not even the gods are free from the Thread of Fate. And so the day came for Dionysos to take up his other mantle, that of Hades, God of the Underworld. He went down to one of the sources of the Styx, which were in those lands, and descended on the river to the realm of the dead. But as he went, Dionysos made his maenads a promise: that in the next Age of the Universe, he would return once more to the world, as the seed that is buried in the ground returns as next year's wheat.

And so the maenads left their magical Kingdom and dispersed among the cities and towns of India, waiting for their god's rebirth.

The Blessing of Dionysos

Chapter Summary

Zeus, who is also called Indra, petitions the Universal Spirit for help against Ravana. The Fates decide to punish Ravana for his hubris.

Now Zeus, who is also called Indra, had come to India long before ever the maenads did, for he has dominions among all the peoples of the earth. He ruled over a magnificent city called Amravati, built for him by Hephaistos to fly in the air above the clouds. Seven stars floated by its side and never set; so that in Indra's city, darkness never fell.

But the Fates punish hubris even in the gods; and so they inspired Ravana, great King of the South, who came from beyond the Ocean and possessed all the ancient wisdom of Babylon, to march on Amravati.

Years and years did the siege last, until the City of Light was plunged in darkness, Hephaistos' engine close to plummeting from the sky; and all the gods there disguised themselves and fled to other lands, as they had done when Typhon marched on Mount Olympos. But this time not even the bravest of the gods could stand against Ravana, nor was there any mountain beneath which they could bury him; for Ravana had a blessing from the Universal Spirit that made him invincible to all gods and demons.

In despair, Zeus-Indra turned to the Universal Spirit. "Lord, save us from this Demon, Ravana! So powerful is he, that he scorns the cities of men and instead casts his eyes upon the cities of gods. Nature Herself stands in terror of Ravana. On his island, Aeolus dares not blow, Helios dares not burn, and Poseidon dares not roar. And now, he has cast me out from my city of Amravati and put the other gods to flight, as in the days of the Titans! Unless Ravana is destroyed, the natural order shall be unmade, and Chaos shall reign once more."

From the darkness over Amravati came a voice, a voice smooth and deep as the flow of the River Styx. Dionysos, God of Gods, spoke from the void and said, "It is true that Ravana possesses a powerful blessing. However, in his pride he forgot to ask for only one thing, one thing that would have made him truly invincible; and his pride shall be his undoing. Eros, lend me your bow."

So saying, Dionysos took from Eros his silver bow and nocked an arrow to the string. He shot the arrow into the mortal world, through a window of Ravana's palace at Mandodari, Ravana's wife. "Whosoever this arrow shall touch, will receive My blessing," the God said to Indra, "and My blessing shall save you."

Mandodari

Chapter Summary

The Arrow of Dionysos, Instrument of Fate, comes into the world through Queen Mandodari of Lanka.

Through the many rooms of Ravana's Labyrinth flew Dionysos' Arrow, invisible and without a sound. Past walls and gardens, through windows and air ducts, passing rooms of carnelian and rooms of lapis lazuli, the Arrow relentlessly sought its mark, deep in the women's quarters of the palace.

Mandodari, chief wife of Ravana and daughter of Mayaa the Architect, awoke with a start for a reason she did not understand. Once, she had been the most fortunate of all women: daughter of a nymph and a student of Daedalos, the sole object of the Great King Ravana's boundless love. Ravana was a man of great wisdom but equally great passion; to the young Mandodari, it had seemed as though his heart knew no limit, so full was he of love for her, love for his people and city, love for his brothers and his sister, love for life itself.

But Mandodari soon discovered that a plumbless heart cannot be filled by one woman alone. Whenever Ravana went out on his wars of conquest, which were many, he returned with women: women of every race and people, and every one of them hopelessly in love with Ravana as though they were maenads and he Dionysos himself. Numerous wings were added to the women's palace until Mandodari felt quite lost in her own home.

And now, after many years and many battles and a great multitude of women, Mandodari slept alone, in a palace of her own. Ravana had hired the best architects of Lanka to build it, Cretan craftsmen to furnish it with silver pipes for hot and cold water, and Egyptian artists to decorate its walls with reeds and deep blue lotus flowers. Mandodari lay on a bed of fragrant cedar wood; but she had not seen Ravana in months, and felt utterly alone.

And the longer she remained thus, the greater grew the sorrow within Mandodari's heart; until sorrow turned to resentment and resentment turned to hate, first of all womankind for seducing her husband away from her, and finally for Ravana himself.

Now Hera was moved with compassion for Mandodari, being herself married to an unfaithful husband. She appeared at Mandodari's window in the guise of a nightingale, after the Arrow of Dionysos had struck. "Fear not, my daughter," sang the goddess, "for your prayers have been heard. You are with child, and you shall bear the daughter Ravana so fervently desires.

"Now, the power to make him pay is in your hands, woman. Now, you hold something to deny him, something to break his heart. Leave this house and go to the forest, where the nymphs and the satyrs live. Make sure your daughter is born there; and once she has come

into the world, you must leave her on the hillside in sacrifice to me. Do this, and I promise you that Ravana shall suffer for his unfaithfulness.”

Mandodari did not tell Ravana that she was pregnant. She sent a message to him, saying she wished to visit her father in his palace under the sea. Ravana did not even appear to wish his wife goodbye. He merely sent her an armed escort of four silent men, to accompany her on her journey.

Mandodari took one of Ravana’s flying craft, great flying ships that could travel among the stars, and crossed the Ocean towards India. By the time the Queen and her escort arrived on that other shore, night was falling and the evening star was high in the sky.

“Make camp here,” Mandodari ordered her escort. “It is late and I’m tired. Light a fire and prepare some food for the night.” While the men set a watch and went out to gather firewood, Mandodari, who as any great Queen was also a powerful sorceress, poured herbs from a secret pouch she wore round her neck into the flour, and mixed them while she made the dough.

The men never noticed that Mandodari did not eat. Before long, they fell into a deep sleep as the drug took effect. Mandodari slit their throats in the night and entered the dark forest that stretched beyond the sand, as far as the eye could see.

Many months did Mandodari wander in that vast wood, from hermitage to hermitage, not knowing where she went. Briefly, she was tempted to return to Lanka and give Ravana the daughter he so desired; the starcraft would come even into the forest at her command. But the memory of Ravana abandoning himself to the charms of other women erased those thoughts, and Mandodari steeled herself in her purpose.

One morning, after a night of dreams filled with blood and love, she found herself at the edge of the forest. In the distance rose the ziggurats and turrets of a magnificent city, sparkling so blindingly in the rising sun that it seemed made of crystal. Feeling her labour begin, Mandodari staggered towards it; but before long, she was overcome, and gave birth to her daughter in a newly-ploughed field outside the walls.

Mandodari stared in wonder at the golden child in her arms. Her daughter was perfect in every way, and a golden glow shone from her that put the sun to shame. It seemed to Mandodari that a goddess had come into the world through her womb. But she knew well Hera’s wrath; and so, her tears falling freely upon her daughter’s face, Queen Mandodari exposed her child in the field in which she was born, and kept her promise to the goddess. She summoned Ravana’s starcraft and flew away unseen, and never looked back.

Thus was the Arrow of Dionysos born into the world.

Divinity Stirs

Chapter Summary

Rama and Lakshman are born into the world: two brothers, inseparable, one mortal, one divine.

The poets of India are masters of the art of memory. Their songs tell of the days before Deukalion's Flood, which not even the priests of Egypt remember. In those days the gods dwelt among men, and men were like gods themselves, not short-lived and feeble as they are today. Great cities stood on the plains of the earth, built by no mortal hand, but by Hephaistos and Daedalos themselves.

In one such city, Ayodhya, an aging King held a sacrifice to obtain an heir.

And in another, Mithila, a young King found a golden girl child in a furrow of his field, glowing like a sliver of moonlight fallen from the sky.

Dasaratha of Ayodhya had four wives, but no sons. Fearing that the House of Ikshvaku the Sun might end with him, he gathered his wives and his sorcerers in a forest on the banks of a sacred river, and held a great sacrifice. A sage with the body of a man, the head and antlers of a giant elk, and serpents entwining his arms emerged from that dark wood. Wordlessly he blessed each woman, and bade her drink a Druid's potion. Before long, each of Dasaratha's queens was with child.

When Janaka of Mithila, out riding with his wife, found the glowing girl child buried in his field, he loved her so much that he desired no other children, no other lands, and was content for the rest of his days. He named her Sita, because he had found her in a furrow of the earth.

In time Kausalya, Queen of Ayodhya, bore Rama, the divine twin; while Sumitra her sister bore Lakshman, the mortal twin. Sacred brothers, born of different mothers and the same father, as Herakles and Iphikles were born of different fathers and the same mother, Rama and Lakshman grew up together as loving twins.

Great was their wisdom, great was their strength, great was their love for their people; so that when the time came for Rama to marry, even Mithila heard of it, and held its breath in hope.

The Bowstring

Chapter Summary

Once again, a man comes to a house filled with suitors, and proves himself to his beloved by stringing a bow that only he could string. But One far greater than Odysseus has come to Mithila.

Now Sita, Princess of Mithila, grew into an amazing young woman. Not only was she a breathtaking beauty; she possessed uncommon kindness, rare especially in one so beautiful, sharp intelligence, deep wisdom, and an even deeper love. Sita loved her adoptive parents dearly, and she cared so deeply for her city that she knew every citizen of Mithila by name.

Naturally, Sita attracted a great multitude of suitors, some of whom came from as far as the Pillars of Herakles at the edge of the world. They came laden with precious gifts for Janaka, and their horses and chariots thronged the streets and squares of Mithila by day and by night.

But Janaka was implacable. He so loved his daughter that he had sworn to give her to none less than a god, for no mere mortal could be worthy of Sita. She seemed a goddess herself, for she inspired worship and ardent love in all who laid eyes upon her.

Now Janaka's line could trace itself back all the way to the first men, those who had sprung from the mixed ashes of Zagreus and the Titans. From those divine ancestors, Janaka had inherited a divine Bow: a weapon that had once belonged to the Universal Spirit Itself. It lay unstrung in an ivory casket, waiting for one strong enough to lift and string it.

"Kings and Princes of the world!" Janaka announced to the suitors assembled in the courtyard of his palace. "Sita shall marry only that man who can string the divine Bow." And a thousand pairs of eyes fixed upon the ivory box, now opened, and upon the glimmering Bow that lay within it. Silvery it seemed, magical, ephemeral as a beam of moonlight.

Oh, how deceptive that weapon proved to be! It seemed so light, so thin, a thing made of dreams and shadows. One by one, the Kings and Princes and great warriors stepped confidently forward, laughing to themselves that the old King had finally lost his wits in his old age.

One by one they reached for the Bow.

And one by one they slunk off homeward, by backways and alleys, under cover of darkness, hoping to escape the shame of being seen too weak to even lift the ephemeral thing. Soon the streets of Mithila were empty of chariots; then its squares and courtyards; and finally even the palace itself was abandoned. Sita, alone in her wing of the palace, despaired of her fate.

Until one night, unexpected by all, a royal chariot arrived. It bore a young prince as radiant as Sita herself, accompanied by his old father and a long-haired sage who seemed both ancient and ageless.

Proudly the sage stepped forward. "This is Rama of Ayodhya, o Janaka!" he cried out. "He has come to win your daughter's hand, and she shall not be disappointed." Janaka and his people stared in amazement, for Rama did not yet know his Fate and was, at this time, exceedingly humble, and Dasaratha his father was a bent old man. Neither seemed to have much hope of stringing Janaka's Bow.

Sita, watching from her window, was overcome with a strange desire. She sat in rapt attention as the sage half convinced, half pushed, his young charge towards the ivory casket. It was opened; the shining Bow glimmered in the moonlight; a hand reached for it eagerly.

"May I touch it?" asked the prince.

"What else have you come for?" answered Janaka. Fascinated, Rama stroked the weapon with his fingertips, while the Bow seemed to pulsate in recognition. Then, in a single smooth movement, he lifted and strung it. The Bow remained thus for a moment, held aloft and vibrating; then, it snapped in two.

A hush fell on all the palace, and Sita rushed down into the courtyard. At the sight of her, Rama was transfixed, tied fast to Sita by the Thread of Fate.

They were married that same night.

The Fates Weave Their Thread

Chapter Summary

Things begin to change in Ayodhya, as the Fates take their course and the gods reveal themselves.

Rama returned in triumph to Ayodhya, with his new bride and the two halves of Janaka's Bow. His mothers and his brothers welcomed him home; as did all the people of that city, for Rama was fiercely loved.

But the Arrow of Dionysos had found its first mark. Soon, things began to change in the idyllic palace. The pull of Sita on Rama's heart became stronger with each passing day, the siren song of Dionysos. Soon, he loved her beyond all reason. Sita awakened within Rama a divine nature he never suspected he had, and struggled to understand. And where first Rama had gone out among his people and knew every one of them by name, now he remained secluded in his palace, giving little attention to the ruling of Ayodhya. He scarcely noticed Bharata and Shatrughna, his two brothers, leaving his city. Only Lakshman remained at Rama's side, for he saw his brother's divine nature and knew himself in the presence of a god.

But Lakshman was not alone in recognizing Rama's divine nature. Kaikeyi, mother of Bharata and one of Dasaratha's wives, had an old maidservant called Manthara. Now Manthara was a wise woman, an old witch, blessed by Hera. She, too, saw the god growing in the prince's heart; and she feared him.

"Listen to me!" she said to Kaikeyi. "Rama is no ordinary prince, and his love is no ordinary love. A god has taken possession of him; a god Who will mercilessly seduce any who stand in His path, a god Who will prove the ruin of our house. Tie yourself to the mast, o Kaikeyi, like Odysseus, and escape the Siren's call. Then you and your son might live. For powerful as he now is, do not delude yourself into thinking Rama will spare your Bharata. The day your son returns home he will be removed, as pretenders to the throne have always been since time immemorial. Keep your wits about you, Kaikeyi, and you may yet save your son's life."

But the power of Dionysos is more seductive than the sweetest kiss, and Kaikeyi's heart was full of burning love for Rama and Sita. "O Manthara, how can you say such terrible things," she said. "Evil old woman, get out of my sight before I call the Kindly Ones upon your head for slandering your wonderful sons!"

And so, Manthara left the palace and went to a sacred grove of ashoka trees beyond the city walls. There, she made sacrifice to Hera, and the goddess heard her. "Return to your city, Manthara," said the oracle, "your mistress and her son shall be saved." And Manthara turned back to Ayodhya in elation, as the first stars showed in the sky.

Triumphant, Manthara went again into Kaikeyi's chamber. This time, to her great satisfaction, she found the young queen in tears. "O Manthara, it is so good you have come! All night long Dasaratha has been with Kausalya. He has eyes only for her. Sumitra stays by her side, and the two of them have turned against me. Manthara, what shall I do? What will these evil women do to Bharata?"

Manthara smiled and thanked Hera for hearing her plea. The rest would be easy. "I thank the goddess for opening your eyes, my dear Kaikeyi. I promise I am with you, and I will both save you and have your son crowned King.

"We must act quickly, before the night ends. Go into your Chamber of Anger, pour ashes on your hair, rend your garments as though in mourning, and send for Dasaratha. When he comes to you, Kaikeyi, remind him of the promise he made, long ago when you saved his life."

For long ago when Kaikeyi and Dasaratha were first married, Dasaratha had gone to war among the sons of Zeus-Indra; and when the war went badly, and Zeus-Indra abandoned him, Kaikeyi had run onto the battlefield and had saved her husband's life.

"I grant you two boons, my love, whatever you want..."

"That you are alive is enough, and will more than suffice. But a day will come when I remind you of your promise."

And so when Dasaratha came to the summons of his youngest queen he found her in her Chamber of Anger, a room stark and bare. Kaikeyi's eyes burned with hatred for her husband, and for his favourite son. Worried and fearful, for he had never seen Kaikeyi like this, Dasaratha rushed towards her. "What happened to you, Kaikeyi? Who has hurt you? Please talk to me, please smile like you used to!"

She never faced him. Lying on the rough earthen floor in a pool of ash and tears, Kaikeyi answered Dasaratha in a voice little more than a whisper. "There is something I want, my lord, something I need more than life itself. Remember the war you fought out on the plains? Remember how Zeus-Indra abandoned you and it was left to me to save your life?"

"Of course I remember, how could I ever forget? But what happened tonight, my love, to leave you in this state?"

"Dasaratha," said Kaikeyi, Hera's imperious voice discernible through her own, "the day has come when I remind you of your promise.

"Two boons you promised me, and two boons I shall ask tonight. First, that Bharata be named your successor to the throne of Ayodhya tomorrow. And second, that Rama be banished to the Dandaka Forest for fourteen years."

Dasaratha fell weeping at Kaikeyi's feet and pleaded with her, threatened her, and finally begged her to relent; but Kaikeyi, fortified by Hera and the Fates, never faltered in her determination. All night long Dasaratha and Kaikeyi fought their battle of wills. When Dawn

came, she found Kaikeyi inhuman, possessed, her eyes burning red like fires; and Dasaratha collapsed on the floor in a swoon, vanquished.

“Get up,” Kaikeyi said as she prodded him awake with the tip of her sandal, “you have work to do.”

That morning was grey, wet, and cold, and thunder could be heard all over Ayodhya. Flocks of black crows flew over the city; the animals brought for sacrifice broke their reins and fled; but in spite of these evil omens, the people of Ayodhya still gathered in the streets and in the palace courtyard. Though things had been strange in the palace ever since Rama had brought his bride back from Mithila, they still deeply loved him and Dasaratha his father.

Dasaratha appeared in his court a broken, bent old man, seated under his white parasol of office. His hair, still black the night before, had gone all grey, and his eyes stared unseeing into the distance. A shiver went through the whole crowd at the sight of him.

“A curse was visited upon me last night,” he said, “and our city must surely have been too magnificent, to have drawn the envy of the gods. For an evil oracle has reminded me of a vow I made in innocent love; and I cannot break it.” He turned to Rama and Lakshman at his side: Lakshman shocked, in disbelief, but Rama strangely calm in the divine prescience that already grew within him.

“People of Ayodhya,” said Dasaratha, “Bharata Rama’s brother is to be your crown prince. And Rama,” his voice now little more than a whisper, “Rama I send into exile in the Dandaka Forest far from here, not to return until fourteen years have passed.”

Dasaratha withdrew into his palace, half carried by his queens and Vasisht his vizier; confusion broke out among the people that bordered on rioting; and Lakshman fell weeping at Rama’s feet, begging his divine brother to explain what was happening. Rama alone remained serene, smiling softly, as though nothing in the whole world could disturb him.

“What worries you, Lakshman?” he asked. “All these things happen only by the hands of the Fates, to whom even gods are bound. And don’t ask me how or why, but I know that Fate has only good in store for us, and for our city.”

The peace of Ayodhya was shattered for good. Vasisht sent for Bharata to return, assuming the regency in the meantime; Dasaratha lay between life and death in his apartments, while the people out in the streets called for his overthrow; soldiers patrolled the alleys of Ayodhya by night, and troublemakers were known to disappear, their belongings sometimes seen floating down the river.

Amarna

Chapter Summary

A young Prince leaves his city to follow the voice of his god, while a wise old vizier trembles at an echo of history.

After many days of anguish, Bharata arrived in a city that seemed gutted by prolonged siege. No one welcomed him at its gates; no music sounded within its walls. As his chariot rode on through the deserted streets, he was finally met by Vasisht, the royal vizier.

“Thank the gods you’ve arrived!” he cried out to Bharata. “Our King and crown prince both have been seized by madness. Dasaratha has banished Rama to the Dandaka Forest after intending to crown him the very day before, and Rama made not the least effort to defend himself!

“Not even my counsel could stop him. He has gone to the Forest already, Lakshman and Sita by his side, and Ayodhya is left leaderless, prey to thieves and bandits. You must help me convince Rama to return, or else take up the Kingship yourself.”

“Come to your senses, old man!” said Bharata. “I refuse to consider taking the throne of Ayodhya from my brother Rama. But I will follow you to the Forest. Whatever his reasons for hastening into exile, surely Rama will relent when his own brother asks him to return.”

And so Bharata went into the palace and embraced his trembling father and all his mothers. “I promise you I will bring him back,” he said, and left with Vasisht the way Rama had gone. From city he passed into verdant fields; from fields into streams and marshes; until finally he reached the banks of the great Ganga, River of the Three Worlds. Here lived men who dwelt in tents, great huntsmen and herders; and their King told Bharat and Vasisht that Rama had indeed come this way, and sent his barge to take them across the River.

The River behind them, Bharata and Vasisht came to the edge of a great Forest, denser than any they had ever seen, dark as a thundercloud. From its heart loomed a great mountain, its slopes mantled in wildflowers, its rocky faces gashed with waterfalls. From that mountain a scented breeze blew down, as from Arcadia itself.

They climbed through dense Forest, elephants and panthers scattering before them as they went; and before long they came to a grassy clearing on level ground, a log cabin at its centre. Here sat Rama in meditation before a sacrificial fire like the oracle priest of a god, Lakshman and Sita by his side. A glow seemed to surround Rama, and he smiled in utter bliss.

“Brother, please,” said Bharata, “you ran away in haste and I understand, believe me, I do. But surely you must realise by now how foolish it all was. Come back with me, become King of Ayodhya; for our father is on his deathbed, and what will become of our city without a King? Ayodhya shall stand unprotected by gods and men, to fall prey to robbers and enemies!”

But Rama merely cast one exultant look at Sita and said, “You do not understand me, dear Bharata. It never was my destiny to be King only of a mortal Kingdom. I’m not sure I understand it myself, but I am here in the Forest not because of Kaikeyi, not because of my father, but by the calling of some god. I hear His song in my heart by day and by night, and I know I am meant to follow it. You are our father’s son, Bharata; you should be King of Ayodhya, not me.”

“Lakshman, won’t you do something?” cried Bharata, his eyes filling with tears. “Won’t you save your brother from this madness that has come upon him?”

But Lakshman shook his head and said, “You never did know our brother, Bharata. Rama is more than a man, more than a King; a divine nature lives within him. Wherever lies his destiny, it is not among the cities of men. Go home, and let us be.”

Then Vasisht, who knew Egyptian lore, spoke up and said, “Listen to me; I am an elder among you. Listen to the wisdom of the ages. Long ago, in the land of Egypt, there lived a young King named Akhenaten. He, too, heard the voice of a god. He left his city and built his god a new capital where he began to seclude himself further and further, until not even his friends and brothers could reach him. Akhenaten lived only for his god’s voice. In the end, his empire crumbled around him, his family disintegrated, his children perished, and his people descended to barbarity and anguish. But still Akhenaten heard nothing, saw nothing, but his god’s voice and his god’s face.

“That young King died a madman, leaving behind a broken empire and a broken people, for Ay his father’s aged vizier to administer. Please, Rama, Lakshman, Bharata, one of you princes, take up your Kingship. Do not leave me to Ay’s fate.”

But Rama, though he had tears in his eyes, for his human nature still felt deeply for Vasisht, had already turned away; and Lakshman and Sita with him. Finally Bharata, taking a pair of jeweled slippers from the royal chariot, placed them before Rama and said, “I will rule Ayodhya, then, but not by my own power. These royal slippers shall be your footsteps and your presence to me, Rama, and I shall always keep them before me, as I reign in your name.”

And so Ayodhya was spared Amarna’s fate, and Bharata returned home with a relieved, if tearful, Vasisht.

Fate comes to Lanka

Chapter Summary

The first of the Moirai makes Herself known by giving an oracle to Lankini, the genius loci of Ravana's city.

But Ayodhya was not the greatest city in the world, despite its protestations to the contrary. For far away in the South, on an emerald green island in a deep blue sea, stood a City built by Daedalos of Knossos himself, the Architect of the Gods. This City was a marvel to behold: it stood like a jewel in the centre of that isle, its streets paved with lapis lazuli, its windows carved alabaster. This was Lanka, the great City of the Rakshasas of the Age, the greatest City in the world.

The Rakshasas were the Watchmen of the Forests of the world, endowed with divine strength and powers. These they used to make Lanka into a City filled with fragrant gardens, surrounded by lush green fields and forests. The whole island was an expanse of rice fields, vegetable patches, and orchards whose trees bore the sweetest fruit throughout the year; while in the gardens within the City's walls a soft rain of fragrant petals fell perpetually from the sky.

At the heart of the City stood Daedalos' trademark masterpiece: a Labyrinth, a House of Many Rooms, twin to the Labyrinth of King Minos of Crete. But where Minos' House was spread out wide in colonnades across the Cretan hills, Lanka's Palace was a piercing stone finger that reached up to the sky. Built entirely of gold and slabs of precious stone, the Labyrinth of Lanka rose vertically, level after level, to dizzying heights. It seemed poised not only to touch, but to conquer the heavens.

From this extraordinary Palace ruled a monarch no less extraordinary than Minos himself: Ravana of Lanka, King of all the Rakshasas of the world. Once, the poets sang of Ravana, he had been one of the great heroes, the men of renown; and in a former life he had seen Deukalion's Flood and had gained great favour with the gods. He ruled the Rakshasas with such wisdom that poets said he needed ten heads to contain it all; with such power that he needed ten arms; and with such lust and desire that he needed ten hearts.

In ages past, Ravana and his awesome brothers had waged war upon all who threatened the Rakshasas, across all the world and even into the Ocean; and so great was Ravana's favour with the gods that none could stand against him, so that ever after his people lived in prosperity and happiness. Rare was the day when ships bearing tribute could not be seen in Lanka's harbours.

And Lanka was unlike the cities of men in one other way: for when Daedalos built Ravana his City, he imbued it with a divine spirit, a nous, a mind that would stand at its gates

undefeated by every foe. Its name was Lankini, and it took the form of a goddess dark as twilight and fearsome as Night Herself.

And undefeated Lankini stood as the generations of men went by. Until one evening at sunset a woman came to Lanka's gates, a lone woman veiled in a white shroud as though she had come from Hades itself. "Spirit of Lanka!" she said. "Listen carefully, for I come to you bearing an oracle from the Fates themselves. Long have you stood invincible at these gates. But remember the Thread of Fate, o Lankini. For one day, at a dusk like this one, a little monkey will come to Lanka; he will strike you down, and he will cut your Thread." Only then did Lankini notice the finely spun thread in the woman's hand, the end still wound round the spindle; and she recognized Clotho, Spinner of Fates.

And as the Sun vanished beneath the horizon, he took the Spinner with him; so that Lankini was left alone with her Fate.

The Enchanted Forest

Chapter Summary

Rama leaves the last vestiges of his former life behind, and begins his journey into the Forest. His realization into Godhood has begun.

For many days Rama, Sita, and Lakshman lived in a Forest clearing, at a place called Chitrakuta. The cool river by their side, the green grass under their feet, the plentiful game and fragrant trees made Chitrakuta a slice of the heavens fallen to earth. The three lived in a log cabin at the heart of the clearing, and felt they could stay there forever. The fourteen years of exile no longer seemed that long.

But in his heart, Rama knew that it was not his Fate to live out his exile in this wonderful wood. One night, Dionysos came to him in a dream. The god was seated upon a crystal throne studded with pearls and corals, two golden Cretan bulls by his side. He stretched out his hand, bearing a thyrsus like a scepter, and Rama saw that the god's throne stood upon an island covered in magnificent gardens, shimmering like an emerald upon the waters.

"Remember your purpose, Rama!" Dionysos called out. "Go South! Go South, face the Forest, and face your destiny."

Rama awoke still dazed by the dream, and set about breaking camp as though pursued by the Furies themselves. Alarmed, Sita ran out to restrain her husband; but Lakshman held her back, saying, "Let him, Sita. You know he is meant for greater things than to spend his life in comfort. The god within him knows what to do. Have faith in Rama, and trust his divine guidance."

And so it was that Rama, Sita, and Lakshman left their home in Chitrakuta and headed deeper into the Forest. They crossed mountains and hills, rivers and streams, treacherous swamps and green woods; and everywhere the creatures of the Forest ran around and before them. Sita learned the language of the birds, who sang her songs, while Lakshman became an ever greater hunter and woodsman, at one with the Forest.

Gradually, slowly, the Dandaka Forest closed in on the travelers, pulling them into its enchantment as a Siren calls sailors to her island. They came to a river, its banks bare and its water muddy, where a group of sages, nearly naked, sat huddled in fear under a dead tree. When they saw Rama, the sages ran out and prostrated themselves before him. They set offerings of fruits and roots before Rama and cried out, "O Lord of the Universe, have mercy on us! For this Forest is infested with rakshasas, great trolls of the woods and mountains. They are vicious maneaters, each more powerful than the strongest tiger, and they have slain many of our number."

“You have more faith in me than I would dare to ask,” said Rama. “I do not believe I am the god you take me for; I am a man, and far younger and less wise than you. But my bow is at your service; be steadfast in prayer, and you shall be saved.”

And so Rama, Sita, and Lakshman went ever deeper into the Forest, in search of vicious trolls to destroy. Though Rama did not know his own divinity, the Forest knew; and it responded to the god’s presence by becoming stranger, more magical, a thing not of this world but of the realm of the gods.

In dark pools, lotuses bloomed whose leaves shone like rainbows. A grove proved to be made all of crystal and precious stone, shimmering in the moonlight, cold to the touch. A dark and twisted path, full of roots and thorns, opened onto a field carpeted with a hundred thousand flowers in a hundred thousand colours, the scent of ambrosia wafting through the air. Thick leathery leaves, the size of carpets, jumped from tree to tree under their own power, golden monkeys riding them as mounts.

And in every place, sages and seers came forth with offerings in worship. Sita and Lakshman looked on at the light in Rama’s eyes: a divine glow that grew ever stronger until his very flesh radiated power. Lakshman looked on in worship; but Sita looked on in dread, her heart missing the humble, shy youth she had married. And as the days became weeks and the weeks became months, Rama, who had first protested his own worship, stopped his protestations when the denizens of the Forest came out with offerings; until finally, he began to expect them as his due.

When the sky disappeared beneath a canopy of leaves, neither Rama, nor Sita, nor Lakshman, noticed the loss.

The Watchman of the Forest

Chapter Summary

Rama and Lakshman encounter the Watchman of the Cedar Forest in an echo of Gilgamesh, as the wilder, more violent aspect of Dionysos reveals Itself.

With neither sun nor moon to tell the passing of the days, the travelers neither knew nor cared how long they traveled through the Forest. After what may have been weeks, or months, or years, they found themselves at the edge of a grove of majestic cedar trees, their fragrance filling the air. "Our path lies through here," said Rama. "The god revealed it to me this night, in a dream." And so Sita and Lakshman followed him into that wood, Sita marveling at the strange trees with their spiny leaves.

Presently they came to a great Tree, taller than all the others. Its trunk was wide as a city gate and thick as a wall, scored with deep grooves. It stood tall as the sky, branches spreading out in a wide canopy, shading the ground beneath and giving shelter to a million colourful songbirds. Seeing Rama approach, the birds all burst into song, and Sita exclaimed, "O Rama, this place is wonderful!"

But Rama and Lakshman looked upon the great cedar with apprehension. "Last night," Rama said, "a sage of the jungle told me that this Forest has a Keeper: a Watchman over all the terrifying rakshasas who defile this place, more terrible than them all. His very breath is fire; each of his arms is strong as a bull and thick as a cedar. To pass through the Dandaka Forest, we must destroy him; and this grove is his palace."

So saying, they took out axes and felled that great Tree; so that the sound of its fall was heard from one end of the Forest to the other.

A frightful cry rang out, followed by a crashing sound like an army of elephants rushing through the cedar grove. Presently a great rakshasa lord stood before them. A fearsome Forest troll he was: his mouth a cavern of fangs, his hands and feet clawed like a tiger's, his eyes red like flames and his breath hot as an oven. He towered over Rama like a tree himself.

"I am Viradha, Watchman of the Dandaka Forest," the rakshasa said, "and you have trespassed too long in my domain. The Universal Spirit Itself placed me here before time began, for the Dandaka Forest was decreed to be the sacred homeland of my kind. And like these other invaders, the men in their ashrams, so you too shall die. But the woman is a tastier morsel: her I shall keep for myself."

And Viradha snatched up Sita with one massive claw, baring his teeth to devour Rama and Lakshman whole. The birds in the branches flew away in terror, screeching.

Lakshman backed away in terror, his courage failing him; but the power of the god took possession of Rama, wrapping him in Bacchic fury. His eyes burned brighter than Viradha's, and his body shone with an unearthly light. Smiling, he drew an arrow and began to sway in dance. Lakshman, regaining his courage, loosed an arrow at the troll, piercing Viradha's flesh so that his blood fell red upon the Forest floor.

Inspired by the sight, Rama and Lakshman both danced lightly and nimbly around the rakshasa, loosing volleys of arrows in a magnificent martial dance from which Viradha could not break free. Finally, the great monster came crashing to the ground like a fallen tree, three arrows stuck deep in his heart.

Sita struggled free of Viradha's dead hand and hid weeping behind a nearby tree, too shocked and terrified to watch. For Dionysos was not yet finished with His sacrifice. Still in the grip of divine frenzy, Rama and Lakshman took the axes with which they had felled Viradha's tree and turned them on Viradha himself. With swift strokes they severed the rakshasa's limbs, his hands and his feet, throwing them into a pit that soon filled with blood like a lake of wine. And in a sacred echo of Zagreus, Viradha was cut to pieces.

At last the divine fury began to loosen its grip on the two brothers. Their movements flagged, the axes fell from their hands, and they stood staring at one another in a daze. Then a forest spirit appeared, a youth dressed all in gold, with fine leaves for hair. An intangible wind seemed to play with his garments, and his red mouth smiled at the brothers.

"May you be ever victorious, o Lord of the Universe!" he said to Rama. "For you have set me free, as the oracle told me you would."

"Who are you, and what do you mean?" asked Rama.

The youth answered, "Once, my name was Tumburu, and I was as you see me now, a muse of the heavens. I sang and danced and recited in the sacred forests and among the stars. But one day I drew the ire of the gods; and Zeus cursed me to be born as a monstrous troll, forced to guard the Dandaka Forest as its Watchman. Over time, I forgot my songs and even my name. But the Father of the Gods had promised me also that one day, Dionysos Lord of the Universe should break my monstrous body and set me free. And see, He stands before me."

Rama asked, "What happened here today? Why did my Fate call me to this grove, to this dark Forest? Why do I hear the god's voice every night in my dreams?"

"Because You, Prince of Ayodhya, are the Lord Dionysos returned to the mortal world as He promised long ago," said Tumburu. "I was fated to be Your first victim; but by no means Your last. Your fate lies elsewhere. Far in the South, beyond this Forest, lies a great City. At its heart stands a Labyrinth; and the King of that Labyrinth is he who draws You. He is Ravana of Lanka, greatest of all the Kings of the world, to whom the heavens and the Underworld pay tribute; and Your arrow shall destroy him, o Lord Dionysos. You, shaker of the earth and of the hearts of men, shall make the whole world dance at Ravana's funeral games."

And with those words, Tumburu danced away into the trees and was seen no more.

Though the god's frenzy had left him, Rama still burned with the fire of Dionysos, his body glowing among the trees. He turned to Lakshman who worshipped at his feet and said, "You saw what we freed from that monstrous troll's body. It is our sacred duty to kill every rakshasa in this Forest; their blood calls out to me to be poured out like wine at a wedding feast."

Now Sita had come out of hiding as Tumburu left and had heard their exchange. She looked at her husband in horror. "Rama, what has come over you?" she asked. "This evil Forest must have cast some enchantment on you, some spirit must have possessed you. Remember how once you knew even the children of Ayodhya by name, and would carry them through the streets? Remember how you loved your people beyond all else, and valued peace above war?"

"Rama, we are strangers to this Forest. Frightful though the rakshasas are, this is their home. Even they have a place in the world, appointed by the gods. If they refuse us hospitality, like Viradha did, then we may defend ourselves. But to slaughter them outright, for blood's sake, is wrong."

But Rama's destiny called him, to a City and a King he did not yet know, but saw every night in his dreams. And he paid no heed to Sita's words; but took her and Lakshman and continued his march. For he knew that he followed a god's path.

The Host of Janasthana

Chapter Summary

The forces of the Dandaka Forest prepare for battle with a god. Once again, Dionysos marches in India, on His way to His true destiny.

Viradha was vanquished; but the Watchman of the Forest had not stood alone. His people had a mighty stronghold at the dark heart of the Dandaka Forest, a great city known as Janasthana. Made all of living wood, more grown than built, Janasthana was a vast structure of woven branches, its streets root-bridges suspended in the air. Colourful lanterns hung from every branch, and the air was suffused with the smell of cooking and the sound of music.

At the heart of Janasthana stood a palace of fragrant cedar wood, home to Khara, Commander of the Forest, Dushana his brother, and Trisiras his companion. With them lived Surpanaka, sister to Ravana of Lanka.

Now Surpanaka was an initiate of the Mysteries of Dionysos, and would often go into the Forest with her women to celebrate the rites of the god. And so it was that one night, while preparing the wine and the ivy, she cast her eyes upon Rama, seeking lotus flowers at the edge of the clearing to adorn Sita's hair.

Recognizing her Lord with the eyes of a mystic, Surpanaka cried out in ecstasy, "My god has shown Himself to me! Please join me, bless me with Your presence, Your light, Your love."

But Rama regarded Surpanaka with calm disinterest. "I have no business with you, rakshasi," he said. Sita stepped forward, moved with compassion for the stricken woman. "Rama cannot come with you, sister," she said, "he belongs to me alone by right of marriage, and cannot be the Orpheus to your rites. But Lakshman is unmarried, and a devotee of the god; perhaps he can join you."

At the first sight of Sita, the Arrow of Dionysos pierced Surpanaka's heart, and she was overcome by a raging, jealous madness. "How dare you take what is mine!" she hissed; then she fell upon Sita with a wordless, strangled scream, as her women fled in terror.

Made strong by Bacchic fury, Surpanaka would surely have strangled Sita, had not Rama and Lakshman intervened and forced her arms behind her. "I understand you, sister of Ravana," Rama said to her, still calm and serene, "but this time, I have come for war, not love. Already I have given you My blessing, the madness that now burns your heart and gives you the strength of a tiger. One more sign I shall give you, for you to take to your brother."

And Rama took out his hunting knife, while Lakshman drew back Surpanaka's head; and together they cut off her nose and her ears. Then Rama sent her on her way; while Sita stood

shivering in terror at the man who was once her husband, but now spoke with a god's voice, a voice that could bring down the sky.

Surpanaka, blood streaming down her face, ran howling back to Janasthana. She threw herself down before Khara as a suppliant, crying out, "How long will you let this insult stand? You let this invader, this man, make his way unopposed into the very heart of our domain. You let him slaughter Viradha and cut down the sacred Cedar Tree. And now look what he has done to me!

"You are a coward, Khara. If you were truly a King, you would kill Rama and his brother and do to that awful woman of his what he has done to me. You do not deserve to rule the Forest."

Khara, who sat with Trisiras his companion in Janasthana's great wooden reception hall, was shocked at Surpanaka's mutilated face. But Ravana had taught him to rule with caution and wisdom; and so he sent Surpanaka to the care of the physicians of the women's palace, and turned to Trisiras.

"Friend, brother, you always were wiser and stronger than I," Khara said to his companion. "I have heard that this Rama is a mortal man; but you saw what he has done to Surpanaka, to Viradha, to our Forest. Surely a great army or even a god fights at his side. How should I meet this challenge? My honour agrees with Surpanaka: we should attack at once, and avenge her and Viradha both. But we are isolated here in the Forest, far from reinforcements, and our enemy has already penetrated our lands."

"You are right to be cautious, friend," answered Trisiras. "Any man who would slay Viradha must have had immortal help. Let us send an expeditionary force, a small number of our great warriors, to go to the cedar grove in secret. There, they can see for us what forces this man has brought with him, and kill him if they can. Without their Prince, Rama's forces must scatter; and his death will pay for Viradha's blood and Surpanaka's insult."

And so it was that fourteen warriors rode out from Janasthana under cover of darkness, headed for the sacred cedar grove. All were armed to the teeth, and could see as well in darkness as in light; and they knew ancient magics to render themselves invisible.

Rama, Sita, and Lakshman meanwhile had reached the edge of the cedar wood, a place where the fragrant trees gave way to a blackness hung with thorny roots and dangling branches. The air turned humid and oppressive, and the sounds of the birds faded until the travelers were enveloped in a thick, heavy silence.

Suddenly Rama halted and drew an arrow from his quiver. "We have visitors," he said softly. Lakshman, too, readied his bow and looked around apprehensively, unable to see in the gloom, but Rama continued, "Mortal eyes cannot see these warriors; so deeply do they fear Me, they dare not show themselves. But they cannot hide from Me. I can feel their hearts, their fears, their hopes, their loves. They long to be set free."

Then Rama cried out in a loud voice, "Warriors of the Forest! I know you. I know you are there. I know who you are. Trust Me, surrender, and I shall grant you your soul's desire, your greatest need."

Fourteen rakshasa warriors materialized around the travelers. Each was tall as Viradha had been, and each was armed with two great bronze axes, one in either hand. They advanced menacingly, closing in on the travelers and leering openly at Sita.

But Rama only stood smiling, as once more the light of the god came over him; and when he loosed his bowstring his movements were faster than any mortal's could be, a shining whirlwind of arrows dancing around the stunned rakshasas like a storm. Lakshman pushed Sita to the Forest floor and shielded her, as Rama's arrows freed the rakshasas of their sins and of their flesh.

Finally, thirteen lay dead, while their comrade, mortally wounded, knelt before Rama. The Prince put away his bow, and lovingly cradled the vanquished warrior's head. "Go to your city, rakshasa," said Rama, "go to your Prince. Tell him Who it is that has come to his Forest." And with that, the last of Khara's warriors ran away into that dark wood, in wordless terror.

Khara's dying warrior reached Janasthana when the sun was already high in the sky. Unable to stand, he clung to his chariot, which carried him into Khara's courtyard. Khara in astonishment came out alone to meet him. "What has happened?" he asked. "How many are there? What size is the army which the Prince of Ayodhya has brought here?"

"One man, my Lord," answered the warrior, his voice a whisper. "Only one man." And with those words, he died at Khara's feet.

Left to himself, without Trisiras there to counsel him, Khara was overcome with fear. He rushed into his palace in a frenzy, leaving chariot and fallen warrior where they lay, and locked himself in his apartments. Here he summoned the captains of the armies of Janasthana, and the great rakshasa sorcerers who had powers to command the earth and the sky, and said to them, "Prepare for war. A great and terrible foe, surely with divine help, marches on Janasthana to ravage us. Bar all the gates and reinforce all the walls, for Janasthana must face a siege or be destroyed."

But Surpanaka, her face bandaged and horrible, her heart burning even hotter with Dionysos' jealous madness, had snuck into Khara's chambers. "You miserable coward!" she screamed at him. "You would lock yourself in your citadel from fear of a man, a mortal. I myself, Viradha, all our warriors, we go unavenged while you cower in a hole like a rat.

"Every night I dream of blood, Khara, the blood of that Prince and his woman flowing on the Forest floor like wine. Give me their blood, as you should! Instead, you cower before a man who should be dust under your feet. Khara, you are not fit to rule."

And so great was Surpanaka's lust for blood that none could restrain her; it took a score of armed men to drag her away.

Khara, more disturbed even than before, sought out Trisiras his companion. "What should I do now? What sort of man is he, who could destroy fourteen rakshasa warriors unaided?"

But Trisiras, who had courage and a thirst for battle, said, "Surpanaka is right. Though this Prince is can be no ordinary man, we cannot sit idly while he destroys our Forest. Yesterday

was a time for caution; today is a time for action. It is time we showed this upstart Prince whose country it is he travels through.”

That very same night, for the trolls of the Forest favour the darkness, Khara, Dushana his brother, and Trisiras his companion rode out at the head of the vast host of Janasthana. Fourteen thousand warriors followed them into battle; a sea of chariots with scythed wheels, bowmen with flaming arrows that never extinguished, dark sorcerers who could command the elements and fly through the air like the gods. The creatures of the Forest fled in terror before that army, and the sages huddled in their huts, praying for deliverance. The very ground shook, and the Forest itself shuddered at the advance of the host of Janasthana.

In the cedar grove, as Sita and Lakshman slept, only Rama kept watch, only Rama sensed the advancing army. And as the light and love of Dionysos flooded his heart, he waited, and smiled.

Panchavati

Chapter Summary

The Epic's first major battle is upon us. We see heroes fight and fall, we see desperation, and above all, the futility of fighting against the gods.

Evil omens gathered in the skies above the army of Janasthana as it moved ever deeper into the Forest. A black cloud rained down blood upon the rakshasas, and a ring of darkness formed around the sun and did not move away. When the army's scouts saw the first cedar tree in the far distance, the leading horse of Khara's chariot team stumbled over a root and broke its leg; and while Khara's charioteer unyoked the stricken animal, a flock of vultures passed suddenly overhead on its way to Janasthana.

A shiver ran through the troops. A few ran into the woods and vanished, leaving their weapons behind on the Forest floor; and faint weeping could be heard in the back of the column. Khara felt a stab of fear himself at these evil signs, and sorely needed courage for himself and for his men. He swallowed his misgivings and said, "What are you afraid of, men of Janasthana? Is it a great army you are on your way to face? You fear no armies. Is it the gods themselves, the host of Heaven you are fighting? You fear no gods.

"No, it is a mere man you are on your way to destroy; a creature that ought to cower in its hut at your approach! This man may have magic, to cast evil against us; but you have killed many sorcerers. He may have favour with some god, who sends us these signs; but you have killed many god-born heroes, and not all the host of Heaven could save them.

"Am I not with you? I, Khara, grandson to Pulastya, one of the Seven Sages who built Eridu, greatest of Cities after the Flood?

"Rakshasas, you have nothing to fear."

Rama, too, had seen the vultures and the darkness, from his camp in the cedar grove. His whole being sang with the approach of the rakshasas; his heart beat in time with their steps as his destiny closed in on him. His bow, ever ready in his hand, sang like the lyre of Orpheus. Forest creatures great and small came to him, and played and danced all around in happy ecstasy, while Sita watched it all in wonder.

Rama turned to his brother. "Lakshman, I fear treachery from Surpanaka. You may not know her well; but I know the jealous madness that consumes her soul. This army does not worry me; but Surpanaka will surely try to harm Sita while I am distracted. I need you to take Sita away to one of the ashrams nearby and guard her there. Do not worry for me; for I sense that the god is with me, and not the whole host of Heaven could stand against me.

“I stay to meet my destiny, Lakshman. Now take Sita and go.”

And so Lakshman took Sita far away from Panchavati, and hid her deep within the Forest. Sita could not resist; she cast one last look at her husband, but he was already far from her, staring into the distance towards Janasthana, consumed by the Spirit of Dionysos within him.

And so it was that Khara's army met Rama all alone, a single man in that vast grove. He stood smiling, his arms open, and his face was the face of Dionysos, his hair the god's flowing locks. The rakshasas halted in confusion as Dionysos-Rama made them His invitation, offered them His deliverance.

“Bring Me all the wildness in your hearts, o rakshasas. I understand it, it is My Kingdom. My gift is the lesser madness which will rest your souls and save you from the greater. You have need of Me.

“For you know not what your life is, nor what you do, nor who you are.”

Now Rama had finally entered upon his destiny, his reason to be born into the world. His body, mind, heart, and soul were suffused with Dionysos, consumed whole by the god's fire. And as he stood watching Khara's army, Dionysos-Rama reflected upon His former life: upon Sita and Lakshman, His father and His mothers, and upon Himself as Rama, young and mortal Prince of an ordinary city-state. And He felt only compassion for all those mortals, including the one He Himself had been. Mortals, after all, do not understand the ways of gods.

At last, shining Dionysos-Rama turned to Khara, His eyes aglow with gentleness and mercy. The rakshasas rallied round their Prince, darkened the sky with their arrows and their javelins; but Rama only stood there, unscathed and unafraid. He set an arrow to His bowstring, and the skies filled with fire, Zeus' thunderbolts raining down upon the rakshasas. The earth itself danced and split, swallowing entire chariot regiments whole.

And so the whole host of Janasthana was routed by a single man, as the fighting men of Thebes were routed by women armed only with thyrsus and ivy leaf. They ran in a panic to Khara for help; but Khara could not save them, could not save himself. He stood staring into Dionysos-Rama eyes and saw there his destiny, saw nothing else.

The rain of fire from the god's awesome bow went on until at last, nothing remained of the vast armies of Janasthana save Khara, Trisiras his companion, and Dushana his brother. Dushana saw the spell which Dionysos had cast over Khara and tried to come to his bewitched brother's aid; but a rain of thunderbolts cut him down.

This finally broke Khara's trance. The Prince of Janasthana threw himself down from his chariot and wept over the remains of his stricken brother, still smouldering on the Forest floor. The god again readied His bow; but Trisiras cast one last look at his beloved companion and threw himself at Dionysos-Rama with a loud cry. “Do not weep for me, Khara,” he said, “for what is better than to give one's life for one's friend?”

Trisiras charged the god, axe raised. His blow struck the bow from the god's hand. But the gods go well-armed into battle. With the labrys, the sacred double axe of King Minos,

Dionysos-Rama cut Trisiras down, severed his arms, his head.

Now Khara stood alone facing the awesome god across a field of blood and ashes that was once his people, his brothers, his friends. Dionysos-Rama smiled at him gently, and set a serpent arrow, sacred animal, to His bow. And Khara threw down his weapons, opened his arms, and weeping welcomed the arrow into his heart.

One warrior alone escaped the slaughter. A charioteer called Akampana survived, hiding under a fallen cedar tree. Once the ground cooled, he snuck from his hiding place, found a lost chariot whose horses were still alive, and fled. Dionysos-Rama sensed the rakshasa's departure and let him. Akampana was to be the god's unwitting messenger, the instrument that would bring Him face to face with His true victim: Ravana of Lanka, the Second Pentheus.

Akampana comes to Lanka

Chapter Summary

We see Lanka again, and catch our first glimpse of Ravana, who also gets his first lines at this point. Some are Ravana's lines from Ramesh Menon's telling of the Ramayana, some are Pentheus' lines from Euripides' Bacchae.

In Lanka, Ravana sat in his favourite garden, overlooking the western ocean. Fountains murmured, while red blossoms drifted on the wind from the flowering ashoka trees.

“...and so you see that Shuruppak, last great King before the Flood, left advice both of a moral and a practical nature,” said a sonorous voice belonging to a bearded old Babylonian master. “He was a man who understood the needs of his people: they needed not only virtue and godliness, but also practical advice on where to best plant their field.”

Opposite the Babylonian sat a much smaller and less ostentatious figure, dressed in a white linen kilt, with the shaven head of an Egyptian priest. He answered in heavily accented Akkadian, “You are right that Shuruppak cared deeply for the struggles of his people. This is indeed the mark of a good King. But still he fell short of the wisdom of the great vizier Kagemni. For fields and oxen and wealth all go to the realm of Osiris; but it is against virtue and piety that our hearts shall be weighed. A truly good King is pious first.”

Ravana listened attentively. He was about to make his reply on the virtue of Kings when Akampana came rushing in, sobbing hysterically. Ravana dismissed the philosophers and calmed his warrior. Finally, Akampana was able to speak and said, “Everyone is dead! The whole city, the whole Forest, Khara and Trisiras and Dushana and our entire host of fourteen thousand, all are ashes, still burning in the cedar grove.”

“Calm yourself,” said Ravana, “and tell me what happened. Did an army attack Janasthana? Why did I not know of it? Whoever it is, don’t they know they cannot escape? Not even the gods themselves can stand against me. We shall go back there, Akampana, and crush them like the insects they are.”

“My Lord, you do not understand,” begged Akampana. “There was no army. There were no divine legions. There was only a man, just one man; or perhaps a god disguised as a man, for he summoned earthquakes and fire from Heaven and destroyed us all. I escaped only by hiding under a fallen tree and rushing here in a chariot. And whenever I close my eyes, I still see his smile: inviting, loving, horrifying.”

Ravana’s eyes darkened, and he was tempted to strike Akampana down where he stood. “One man, you say? One man destroyed fourteen thousand warriors? And you expect me to believe this? Are you sure you haven’t run away from a battle like a coward, and drunk yourself into

a stupor?" But one look at Akampana's eyes made Ravana lower his hand. He saw no drunkenness there, only sheer terror.

"How dare he, this upstart who hides in the woods like a beast and calls himself a god. Lanka is the greatest Kingdom that ever stood upon the earth, and I am its King. This godling, this beast of the Forest is not worthy of the dust beneath my feet. I shall go to the Forest myself and deal with him."

"Oh no!" Akampana cried out. "You don't know what you're saying! I watched as our greatest champions were torn limb from limb by the stroke of the labrys. I saw the earth and the sky move, split, and bleed at this god's song. Had you been there and witnessed these things, you too would have entreated with prayer the god whom you now revile."

"I cannot sit here and let this foreign upstart, whether god or mortal, ravage my Forest," answered Ravana.

"There may be one way by which you could defeat this god," Akampana said. "He cannot be vanquished in open battle; but he is an emotional sort of god, deeply attached and feeling. He has a wife, Sita. She is to him as his own flesh. Take her, and Rama will come willingly into your hands."

That evening, Ravana called his court into his Cretan reception hall. Frescoes adorned every surface, depicting sea-creatures locked in battle with long-limbed octopus. In the centre of the hall stood Ravana's throne, a magnificent structure of Indian ebony inlaid with Cretan pearls and corals, a golden bull standing at either side.

Ravana addressed his ministers, "Men of Lanka! I am informed that a new god from the north has arrived in the Dandaka Forest. He has wreaked havoc on the men of our city there, has molested my sister, murdered my cousins, and worst of all, he has bewitched my men.

"Already it blazes up at my feet like fire, the insolent fear of this upstart godling. Already Akampana of Janasthana came to me bewitched with terror of this new god, telling me to worship him.

"Rakshasas, we are men of the City. We do not bow to wild gods from the barbarous woodlands. I cannot face this disgrace to my name. At dawn, I shall go myself to the Dandaka Forest, where I shall crush this foreign godling. He shall know the true meaning of power and fear."

So saying, Ravana left his hall, to the thunderous cries of his people.

Thebes and Pentheus

Chapter Summary

Ravana makes his first foray into the Dandaka Forest; but the warning of the Bacchae turns him back. Dionysos has strung His bow; but His Arrow has not yet found its mark.

At first light the next morning, Ravana sat in the strangest chariot. It was made of pure silver, and six antlered creatures were yoked to it. Dancing green light surrounded that vehicle, shot through with flashes of purple. When Ravana was ready, his chariot rose into the air; with a wave of his hand it flew northward, quick as the winds themselves.

It had been many years since the Lord of Lanka had flown in this silver sled. It had been a wedding gift, from Katla, Ravana's brother's wife. Long ago this great lady, large and strong as a mountain, was married to Kumbhakarna Ravana's brother. But Katla was fiery and desirous of power. Not content to remain in her husband's house, she ranged across the earth in search of lands to rule.

She flew and flew, but every place she came to had a King already. Finally, Katla reached the Pillars of Herakles in the Western Ocean; here she halted, and with her magics created for herself an island in the Hyperborean Sea, where snow falls all year long and fire dances in the sky. Katla became Queen of her island, and her children are the great stone trolls of Hyperborea. They are marvelous sorcerers, bards, and silversmiths; and so, they built a magical flying chariot, all of silver and dancing light, for Ravana their lord.

Ravana sat in this chariot wrapped in a white linen cloak against the wind, as the sled flew through the air. Within moments, land came into view, a pristine beach with forested hills behind it; and soon, Ravana found himself over the Dandaka Forest. His chariot circled down and down until the green carpet below him turned to towering trees. The flying animals touched down soft as a feather, and Ravana stepped out onto a mossy clearing surrounded by towering pipal trees, their root-like tendrils hanging down all around. At the heart of the clearing stood a rustic log cabin, Ravana's destination. A bent old rakshasa, with grey skin and long white hair and beard, came rushing out with a cry of welcome.

"Dearest nephew!" he called out, "I haven't seen you in ages! Welcome to my grove. What brings you to the Dandaka Forest?" For the old hermit was Maricha, Ravana's uncle. Years ago, he had been initiated in the Mysteries of Orpheus by a travelling Phrygian, and ever since had lived a life devoted to music and meditation, avoiding meat, onions, and garlic as the Orphics do.

"I have come here to seek your counsel, Uncle," said Ravana. "A god has arrived in these Forests: a new god, from some faraway, barbarous place. He appears as a man, I am told; but alone he laid waste to all the host of Janasthana, molested my sister, and murdered my

cousins. You are wise, Uncle, and you know many esoteric secrets from foreign lands. Help me destroy this upstart godling, and avenge my city and my kinfolk.”

Now Maricha had practiced the Dionysian Mysteries for many years; and following his master Orpheus he knew by heart all the ancient songs of Dionysos. He sensed the strains of a familiar tale, and cold terror crept into his heart.

“Ravana, dear nephew, you know I have only your best interests in mind,” said Maricha. “Therefore, take my advice on dealings with foreign gods.” He led Ravana into his cabin and sat him down on a rug in the centre of the floor; then took his lyre from its hook upon the wall.

“There was another King once: the strong, youthful ruler of a great City. One day, a man came to his gates, a strange, feminine, foreign man, who brought dancing barbarian women in his wake. They danced and sang, ate roots and wild honey, and spoke to the birds of the air and the creatures of the earth. The man told the King, whose name was Pentheus, that a god had graced his city with His presence, and he should pay homage. But Pentheus refused. He was a proud man of the City, and would not bow to a god from the barbarous hills.

“The god then drove all the women of the City mad with His frenzy; still, Pentheus did not render worship. Next He destroyed the men of the City, armed men routed by women, their weapons useless; still, Pentheus did not relent. Even when the god called an earthquake upon the City, Pentheus remained headstrong.

“The strange man who had come to Pentheus’ gates was, of course, none other than the god himself. And in the end He came to Pentheus kindly, gently, beseeching and entreating the King to accept His mercy, to save himself. But Pentheus became ever more vengeful and enraged. He prepared to make open war on the god, to destroy the stranger and his followers. But the god, His mercy rejected again and again, toyed with Pentheus as a tiger toys with his prey. He drove that poor King mad, out of his senses; and his own mother tore the flesh from his bones with her bare hands.

“And throughout it all, the god never ceased to smile, never ceased to offer mercy if only Pentheus would surrender and welcome Him. But He offered in vain; for the god’s own madness was upon Pentheus, clouding his mind and blinding his heart.

“That god was Dionysos, Ravana, Whom our sages call the Universal Spirit. Practice caution, my nephew, and wisdom, and humility. Do not draw the ire of the strange god you speak of; for if he is who he seems to be, you stand in grave danger of meeting Pentheus’ fate. You have many enemies, Ravana, lesser men who envy you your wealth and power. Surely one of these has planted this evil seed in your heart.

“Leave this Forest, dear nephew, and do not seek war with Dionysos, but humbly ask Him for His blessing. This shall bring you fortune and happiness in this life, and freedom in the life to come.”

And Ravana, inspired, left his uncle’s hut and flew back to Lanka, the verses of the Bacchae still echoing in his heart. Dionysos had strung His bow; but His Arrow had not yet found its mark.

Prologue to the Bacchae

Chapter Summary

Dionysos leads His companions, His first two maenads, to Mount Cithaeron. The stage is set for the play to begin.

Now Rama, Sita, and Lakshman still dwelt near the Cedar Forest, at the place where Lakshman had hidden Sita during the great battle with the host of Janasthana. Dionysos-Rama taught them to fashion pipes from wood, to sing like the birds and to dance like the wind, and the two travelers and their god lived in happiness and plenty. Sita had carved herself a thyrsus and when she struck the rock, clear water gushed forth; and the ground ran with streams of milk, honey, and wine.

But the god knew that His time was at hand; and so one morning he presented Lakshman and Sita with tunics of dappled fawnskin and said, "I hear the Fates calling Me to the South, to Lanka, to deliver Ravana from himself. Come, break up your camp and follow Me. Bring only your weapons and your thyrsi and leave all else behind. You shall wear fawnskin like the maenads of old, to show to all the world that you belong to a God."

And so Dionysos-Rama and His two companions went once more upon their way, dancing and singing as they traveled; and the birds of the air and the creatures of the earth danced beside them, as they had done for Orpheus all those years ago. The god's Spirit took hold of the Forest, and the trees and the hills swayed in dance, keeping time with Dionysos-Rama's step.

And the sun set and the sun rose, many, many times; still the travelers did not rest, for the power of the god inspired them. And the closer they came to their destiny, the more the Forest changed to match their purpose. Trees turned to shrubs, grass turned to thorns, green turned to grey, as the Dandaka Forest became sparse, spindly, carnivorous. Thorny bushes grew everywhere, and bulbous flesh-eating plants dripped blood. What trees and grass remained seemed scorched as though by lightning, like the Titans. But still the earth and the sky danced with Dionysos; and Sita and Lakshman feared nothing, for the god was with them.

After many days of travel, they came to a clearing of bright green grass, wet with dew, amidst tall pine trees. At its heart stood an empty log cabin, in pristine condition, perfect and inviting and waiting for them. Here Dionysos told his companions to halt; and the god's Spirit withdrew once more, allowing Rama to be human again.

Rama and Lakshman his brother embraced one another and Sita, shaken after the battle and the journey and the burning, unrelenting presence of the god; then they set about hunting

game and building an altar to Dionysos. And there they lived, in that faraway echo of mount Cithaeron, for many happy days.

The Arrow Of Dionysos

Chapter Summary

Ravana is persuaded back to the Dandaka Forest one final, fateful time. This is the turning point of Dionysia, the point where Ravana seals his Fate by his own lust, as it is the turning point of the Bacchae.

"Don't you want to see, Pentheus?"

Ravana arrived in his City when the sun was high in the sky. He handed his flying chariot to his grooms, and went straightaway to his Library. Now Ravana was a brilliant scholar and a passionate collector of ancient texts. From his great conquests and his many vassals he had amassed a marvelous collection of tablets of clay and of wax and of precious stone, upon which was recorded all the wisdom of the world.

The Library of Lanka was a Labyrinth in itself. Room after room Ravana crossed: each paved with a mosaic depicting a different ancient scene, each storing hundreds of tablets, carefully labeled, within niches in its walls.

Finally he came to the centre of his Library, a room furnished with carpets, cushions, and low tables. Here Ravana sat; and here he summoned his philosophers, scholars of the Library who came from around the world.

"I have heard the most extraordinary tale," Ravana said to the wise men assembled around him. "I have heard that deep in the Forest, the Universal Spirit dwells in the guise of a mortal man, a Prince of Ayodhya. I have heard a poet's words sung to me of Dionysos and of Pentheus, King of a great City like my own.

"You know wisdom and secrets from many distant lands. So tell me all you know of this god and his ways, and of Pentheus and his City."

And the scholars of Lanka told Ravana of the Mysteries of Dionysos, which may not be repeated here to the uninitiated. And Ravana understood the power and the purpose of the god; but in his heart he did not believe that the young Prince of Ayodhya was truly Dionysos reborn into the world.

But before Ravana could leave his Library a great commotion arose in one of the further rooms, as Surpanaka, her face noseless and horribly disfigured, burst into the central hall. Ravana quickly dismissed the philosophers and tried to address her, but Surpanaka would not be silent.

"What sort of brother are you, what sort of King, who will not avenge his own flesh and blood?" she cried out. "Day after day I sat in the empty ruin of Janasthana, waiting for you.

My men died, my women deserted me, yet still I believed in you. The great Ravana of Lanka, King of the Universe, would surely come to my aid.

“Yet did you come to me? Have you avenged your sister as you should? No. Instead, I am told, you flew to the Dandaka Forest only to slink back to your palace like a coward, turned away by the fables of poets. You are a worthless brother and a worthless King, not worthy of the name.” And she wept and raved like a Bacchante herself; but Ravana, wise and cautious, remained calm.

Then the Spirit of Dionysos, Who is Lord also of pleasure, spoke through Surpanaka. “You don’t know what delectable fruit you are missing, out there in the Forest,” she said. “Sita, Rama’s wife, is the most delightful, irresistible little morsel. Her face is like a lotus flower; her body is perfect; she knows the language of birds and can make the very Forest dance when she dances, weep when she weeps. This girl enchants all who lay eyes upon her; she’s a spell woven by Eros himself, the perfect object of desire. This little princeling isn’t worthy of having her, and you know it.

“Don’t you want her, Ravana? Don’t you want to have her, taste her? Don’t you want to see? You know you do. No one lusts for beauty like you do, my brother. And you always, always, get what you want.”

Now Ravana, though wise, was also lustful: a great lover of beauty and power, and a collector of beautiful women. Surpanaka’s words set his heart aflame; so that he could not rest until Sita was his, to hold and to possess.

Thus was the Arrow of Dionysos loosed from its bow; and the first stirrings of Bacchic frenzy, the madness that once consumed Pentheus, fastened upon Ravana’s heart.

The Arrow Finds Its Mark

Chapter Summary

The madness that took Pentheus takes hold of Ravana's mind and heart for the first time. Using Orphic sorcery, he takes Sita, the Instrument of Fate; and his death is set in motion. *Alea jacta est*.

I have here attempted to accentuate the chaotic nature of the scene by using *stichomythia*, a technique from Classical Greek theater in which actors alternate saying one line each.

I have only seen this at work in verse, and with two actors in the scene; I have here attempted it in prose, and with four actors. It remains to be seen whether I am successful.

Ravana had entered his Library thoughtful and composed; now he left it as a man in a drunken stupor. He made his way back to his chariot platform as night fell over Lanka, Surpanaka giggling with glee by his side. Soon, Ravana was in the air once more, his chariot's ghostly green light dancing around him. Deep in the night, the strange vehicle touched down again beside Maricha's cabin, now entirely shrouded in darkness. Ravana, Bacchic frenzy building in his heart, nearly broke down his uncle's door before a terrified Maricha could open it.

One look was all it took to confirm Maricha's fears; one look at his nephew's frenzied eyes showed him the madness that was the hallmark of his god, the divine ecstasy of Dionysos. Maricha knew better than to oppose the Universal Spirit, knew that Ravana's fate was sealed as Pentheus' had been before him; but his love for his nephew overrode his wisdom.

"Ravana, please," he begged, "I've told you all I can. Please calm yourself, do not let this madness consume you! It is not your own heart that drives you, it is the god's frenzy. Dear nephew, please turn back and save yourself. You are greater than Pentheus; you need not share his fate, if you will only turn back and put Sita out of your mind."

But Ravana was beyond all reach. "Maricha, dear uncle," he said, a menacing edge to his voice that had not been there before, "If you know what is good for you, you'll come with me." Ravana possessed near unlimited power, even without the god's madness. Maricha knew he had no choice, saw the Fates cut the Thread of his life. Meekly he stepped into the magical chariot, and guided his nephew to the place where he knew his god to be.

Ravana's chariot set itself down at the edge of the pine clearing in which Dionysos-Rama's log cabin stood. A single flickering light could be seen within. Ravana was about to stride forward and take what he wanted by force, but Maricha prevented him.

“Sita is exceedingly loyal to her divine husband,” Maricha said. “She is bound to him by great love and powerful magics. She will not come with you willingly, Ravana, nor will you be able to overpower the god and His followers in direct confrontation. Practice caution, my nephew. We must use sorcery to defeat sorcery.”

And so Maricha, who knew many of the highest Mysteries, used the magic of his master Orpheus to become one with the Forest. Within moments, where Maricha had been now stood a golden deer, a magnificent animal. Its hooves and antlers were solid silver, its coat shone like the sun, and a golden glow emanated from it.

“Marvelous, uncle!” Ravana cried out. “Now run and dance among the trees, and snare me my prize.” And so Maricha, disguised now as the golden deer, ran nimbly through the clearing, and jumped away into the trees.

Sita lay awake that night; strange dreams and omens had kept her from sleep. In the darkness she sat at her shrine to Hera, protectress of married women; but when she had lit the fire upon her altar, her eye was caught by a golden glow coming from the trees, more magical than any lamp. A deer stood there, large and majestic, its fur all of gold, its hooves and antlers all of silver. The animal regarded Sita calmly, with not a hint of shyness, and an almost-human intelligence shone in its eyes.

An excited Sita ran back into the log cabin she shared with her two protectors, her offering to Hera forgotten, and woke Rama. “Dear husband, can you see that magnificent creature outside our door?” she asked. “I’ve never seen its like, not even in this strange Forest; and when I speak to it in the language of birds it does not answer. Please, will you capture this enchanting beast for me, so that I may learn his language and become his friend?”

Now the Spirit of Dionysos had retreated from Rama; he was once more fully human, without divine knowledge of the fates of men, and wanted nothing more than to please Sita. And so he woke Lakshman his brother and said, “I am going out to hunt this deer Sita has seen. Stay with her and keep her safe; and whatever you see or hear, do not leave her. The god’s oracles are never far from me, and they are telling me that sorcery is with us in this place.” So saying, Rama took his bow and disappeared into the Forest, in pursuit of the deer that fled from him.

Maricha’s heart cried out when he saw Rama come for him. For a moment, he hesitated, wanting with all his soul to embrace his god, to surrender and dance and call out Dionysos’ name. But he felt Ravana’s hungry eyes close behind, and saw the glint on Rama’s arrows; and so Maricha took fright and ran, further and further into the Forest.

Deeper and deeper did Maricha lead Rama into that wood, until neither knew quite where he was and Maricha could run no more. In desperation he turned to face his god, and in that moment Rama knew him. “You have been so very faithful to Me, Maricha,” said Dionysos-Rama. “You deserve to be set free.” With those words the god loosed His arrow; and Maricha, delivered at last from all fear and all suffering, welcomed it into his heart. But in his dying moments, Maricha remembered his nephew; and so with his last breath called out in Rama’s voice, “Lakshman, help me!”

Maricha's terrible cry echoed through the trees, and Rama, the god's oracular fire having left him again, was for a moment unsure of what to do. Lakshman meanwhile had heard the cry too, and his heart turned cold. He wanted desperately to rush out and seek his brother, but Rama's words of parting resounded in his mind.

"Whatever you hear, whatever you see, do not leave her..."

And so Lakshman restrained himself, summoning all his strength and courage to remain by Sita's side.

But Sita had made no promise to Rama. When she heard her husband's voice cry out and saw Lakshman standing motionless, she flew into a rage. "How can you stand idle, while your brother suffers? Why aren't you with him, why did you ever let him go out alone?"

"Oh, I know. I know the vile heart you hide behind that awesome show of piety. It was you who encouraged my husband to go to the Forest. It was you who once wanted him to murder Bharata, his brother and your own. It was you who left him to face a demon of the Forest on his own, pretending to protect me, knowing that Rama with his pure heart would never suspect you of anything.

"Did you think I never saw the lust for power in your heart, never saw how you always wanted the throne of Ayodhya for yourself? Do you imagine I couldn't see you plot against your brothers, couldn't see you try to remove all who stood in your way? It was more than love that drove me to follow my husband into exile, o Lakshman. I know you for the traitor that you are."

Sita's eyes burned with hatred, and Lakshman, distraught, fell at her feet. "The gods have surely abandoned us, my sister," he said, "for you must be bewitched to say such things. Rama is my life, sister, my very breath and soul. What demon, what foul enchantment, could have taken possession of you to make you say these things? I remained with you only because Rama himself told me to, warned me of sorcery. I acted only out of love and faithfulness to him.

"But if you truly believe these things, Sita, if you truly hate me and think me a traitor, then my life is forfeit; I shall lay down my life right here at your feet, for I no longer have any reason to remain in this world."

"Suicide will not prove your loyalty," answered Sita, "it is a gesture fit only for tyrants and poets. You are a warrior. If you are truly loyal, go out right this moment and help your brother. Then, if Rama returns with you alive, I may one day forgive you."

And so Lakshman took his bow and ran, tears in his eyes, out from Sita's door; but before he left, he drew a line in the earth before the threshold and said, "This line is a warrior's protection, my sword and my bow. None shall cross it with an impure heart." And with those words, Lakshman vanished into the night.

After Lakshman had gone, Sita's fury left her. Suddenly all alone for the first time in ten years, she sat in the oppressive silence of her log cabin. Her shrines no longer brought her comfort; the night seemed so much darker than before, the trees outside her window turned to

menacing shadows. Sita regretted her harsh words to Lakshman; but wish as she might, she could not undo them.

Ravana, meanwhile, watched Lakshman's departure with great pleasure from his hiding place among the trees. His heart burned with a Bacchic fury that left him blind to all but Sita. Gone were his uncle, his sister, his Kingdom, even himself; all that remained in Ravana's heart was hunger, the hunger of a Bacchante for the flesh and blood of the Mystery.

He took one step, then faltered. The line, the magical line that Lakshman had drawn upon the earth, held his gaze and his step and would not let him pass. But Ravana had come too far to be deterred from his goal. Quick as the wind, he flew back to Maricha's clearing, put on his uncle's fawnskins, slung his uncle's lyre across his own shoulder, and returned to Sita's cabin.

Sita sat weeping in the darkness when she heard the soft knock on her door. She opened it just a crack; and saw there a smiling Orphic sage, dressed in the fawnskins of Dionysos, lyre in hand. "O great Lady, why do you weep?" said Ravana.

"My husband lies injured in the dark Forest," answered Sita, "and in my anger and grief I drove away the only man who could have saved us both. Now, not even Hera will answer my prayers anymore."

But Ravana said, "O Lady, do you not know that to us Orphics the owls and the fireflies whisper secrets in the night, as once they did to our master Orpheus? I have traveled far, o Lady, and I am weary. If you let me in, if you give me a place beside your hearth, I will set your heart at ease. For I can tell you where your husband is, and what his fortune will be." And so spellbinding, so strangely familiar was this figure, that Sita could not help but open her door further and further the longer she looked at him.

"Give rest to my body, o Lady, and I shall give rest to your soul."

"But what do you know of my husband?"

"Rama, where are you?"

"Why did you leave her, Lakshman, you swore to me you wouldn't leave her!"

"You are always welcome, o Lady, but please... let me sit by your fire, I'm so tired after my travels."

"But how are you not injured, Rama, and where is the deer?"

"My brother, I warned you of sorcery in this accursed place!"

"We must run, Rama, run like the wind, save Sita from this evil sorcerous Forest!"

"Then welcome to my home, o venerable sage."

"Ah, but it is not I who shall enter your home, o Lady; but you who shall enter mine."

With those words Ravana, his grip strong as only a rakshasa's can be, took up Sita and carried her to his waiting chariot. They were gone long before ever the brothers returned.

The first rays of the sun struck Ravana's silver chariot as he flew his prize back to Lanka. At first Sita struggled, cried out, flowers and jewels falling from her hair; but Ravana held on ever more tightly, until she quieted for fear he would crush her. Nothing of his humble Orphic disguise remained; his fawnskins shed, Maricha's lyre broken upon the ground, Ravana now was only regal, all awesome power and irresistible strength.

All Ravana's thoughts were Sita, all his senses were Sita, his very breath and life were Sita. He had forgotten Maricha, forgotten Khara, forgotten even his own Kingdom. Even the wind as he flew through the air he no longer felt. He never noticed Sita's tears, never felt her struggle, never saw her anguish at becoming an Instrument of Fate. Ravana knew only exultant happiness, the madness of Dionysos that once took Agave having taken full possession of his heart and mind and soul.

Thus did the Arrow of Dionysos finally find its mark. And in the dark depths of Hades, Atropos, third and oldest of the Moirai, cut Ravana's Thread.

The Hidden Jungle City

Chapter Summary

Dionysos meets once again His former maenads, and regains His army of lovers.

When Rama and Lakshman his brother came again to their log cabin, they found it empty. The fire extinguished, the door ajar, Lakshman's magical line trampled underfoot; and however loudly they cried her name, of Sita there was no sign.

All grew dark in Rama's heart and mind, and he turned to his brother. "Why did you leave her when I told you not to? Why did you not listen when I warned you of sorcery? She's gone, Lakshman, gone, murdered perhaps by some terrible Forest troll, and it is your fault. You left her defenseless!"

And in his grief Rama was overcome by the Spirit of the god and became terrible to look upon. His eyes flashed fire, the earth shook so that the logs of the cabin threatened to come apart, and one by one the stars went out. Rama took hold of Lakshman and shook him; and, weeping, Lakshman cried out in terror, "I didn't want to leave her! But I had to; she accused me of terrible things, said I wanted you dead so I could rule Ayodhya myself. I had to prove to her that I loved you, Rama. She was seized by madness."

But Rama was beyond reason. Such was the power of Sita that not even the god Himself could keep from loving her beyond all else. The earthquake continued, and at the god's command all the serpents of the Forest rose up and came speeding, writhing, to destroy Lakshman for his failure. But Lakshman fell prostrate before his brother and said, "Please have mercy, Rama, this fury isn't you. I acted only from love of you and of Sita. I swear to you I will not rest until I find her again, and whatever demon took her is punished for his impiety."

At those words Rama's anger cooled, and the divine Spirit stopped shaking the earth. The first light of dawn now crept among the trees, and the brothers left their cold, empty cabin. Flocks of birds and herds of deer led their way as omens do, drawing Rama and Lakshman ever southwards, to the edge of the Forest and the edge of the sea.

Many days did the brothers travel through that dark wood: no longer beautiful now, all black thorns and strangling vines and poison. Rama moved in an ever-grimmer silence, while Lakshman quaked in terror beside him. All memory of lyre and dance was forgotten; Dionysos now was only terrible, no longer gentle.

At last they saw a gleam of light, real sunlight, through the blackened trees. The great Dandaka Forest ended in a row of scraggly shrubs; and before them stood a woman dressed in white, a measuring rod in her hand. Rama recognized Lakshesis, second sister of the Fates, and halted.

“Bromius, You know who I am,” the woman said to Rama. “I have measured the Thread of Ravana of Lanka, and I am done with my work. Why do You tarry? It is time for Ravana to meet his Fate.”

But Rama was yet still mostly human, and did not possess the full knowledge of the god. “Great Moira,” he answered, “I know my destiny lies beyond this place. But Sita, whom I love more than my own soul, has been taken from me. I can do nothing until I find her.”

“Why, none but Ravana himself has taken Your beloved. But the great Dionysos does not travel alone to His purpose. It is Your Fate to destroy Ravana; but You shall do so with an army of maenads by Your side, wielding the might of the wild forest against the hubris of the city.

“Beyond the woods, in stony places, You shall find Sugriva, Your chief maenad. He will come to You in humility, and You shall know him by the strength of his devotion. With Sugriva by Your side, Your maenads restored, You shall destroy Ravana. So speaks the Thread of fate.” With these words Lakshesis moved from the path; and though Lakshman looked for her, she could not be found.

The brothers left the Forest behind them, finally under the open sky again after more than ten years. The sunlight stung their eyes. But Dionysos-Rama no longer paid it any mind, for He saw ahead a great treeless rock, surrounded by boulders. A monkey jumped down from the rock; and the brothers saw he held pipes in his hand, like a satyr.

The monkey wore the fawnskins of a Dionysian mystic, and prostrated himself before Dionysos-Rama. “So the oracles are true,” he said, “our god, the great Dionysos, Zagreus, Bromius, has finally returned to us.”

But Dionysos-Rama raised up the monkey and said, “An oracle told Me I would find My maenads at a stony place. Tell Me, monkey, who are you, and do you know the way to Lanka? It is time for Me to fulfill My purpose.”

“We are musicians and poets of the hills and forests, o Bromius,” said the monkey. “We have been devoted to You alone for as long as the stars have lit the night sky; eating no meat, no onions, no garlic, composing song and poetry in Your name. Long ago You taught us to live in the forests of the world and to embrace the wildness in our hearts, which You rule; so that we have kept our fur, like the satyrs of Phrygia, in Your honour.

“But please, my Lord Bromius, allow me to take You to our mountain. There, some of our number live with Sugriva our former King. He is wise and ancient; he can tell You of our history and our devotion to You much better than I can.”

The monkey, who introduced himself as Hanuman son of Aeolus, took Dionysos-Rama and His astonished brother to a cave halfway up a nearby hill. The green canopy of the Dandaka Forest spread out in the distance below them like a vast carpet. Dionysos-Rama’s eye was drawn to an aged monkey, who crouched down in the cave mouth.

“Have no fear,” He said to the monkey elder. “Long ago, in another land and another age, I lived in the mountains as a young man. I had a tutor then, an old satyr named Silenus. I did

not even know I remembered him, until I saw you.”

“I expected You would know me, Lord Bromius. You are reborn into the world, a new man with new blood; but the part of You that is divine and unchanging remembers me. I am Sugriva. I remember You, o Lord, and I have instructed my people in Your rites and initiated them into Your Mysteries.

“Now hear the tale of the Kingdom of Kishkindha. Long ago, when the Universe was young and the Titans walked the earth, You came to this land. Your maenads, who lived by Your every word, followed You here; and You taught them to plant vineyards, to make pipes and lyres, and instructed them in all the arts of music, poetry, and ecstasy.

“When Your Will was fulfilled, You descended to the Underworld; but You promised Your people that You were never far from them, and that one day, You would return so that the Universal Spirit may be known again.

“Many years did Your maenads wait, practicing Your Mysteries, finding enlightenment for their souls and freedom from rebirth through Your guides to the Underworld. The Kingdoms of the earth spurned the maenads, all the great cities cast them out, but still they remained faithful. And today, their hopes are fulfilled.

“O Lord Bromius, we the monkeys of the forest are Your maenads, and we have waited so long for You. We built a city of our own, but not like the cities of other men; Kishkindha is a city of the wild forest, dedicated wholly to You, hidden from men’s eyes as the Mysteries are.”

Sugriva’s eyes lost their ecstasy and gained a covetous gleam when he spoke of Kishkindha. He cast a sidelong glance at Lakshman and continued. “I would have received You there, my Lord, You and Your honoured companion, were it not for my treacherous brother Vali, who stole my throne and drove me from my city.

“Lord Bromius, You are a force not only of pleasure but also of justice, as You were to Pentheus of Thebes long ago. Vali profaned Your rites by taking the sacred city of Kishkindha for himself by force. Do to him as You did to Pentheus, o Lord Dionysos, and we maenads shall be free once more to follow You to the ends of the earth.”

Lakshman, who had listened in silence, cast a doubtful look at Sugriva. “Who are these people? How will they help us find Sita? They don’t seem any closer to Lanka than we are; and if they have indeed lived secluded in the forest for an Age of the Universe, as they say, how will they help us find and conquer a Kingdom such as Lanka’s?”

But Dionysos-Rama looked long and hard at Sugriva. He recognized in the old monkey’s eyes the fierce devotion Lakshesis had prophesied. “My brother and I will gladly help you win back your city, venerable Sugriva,” he said.

The Death Of Vali

Chapter Summary

Dionysos-Rama kills Vali, King of Kishkindha, so that Sugriva becomes His chief maenad in accordance with the Fates. He comforts Vali with a telling of the Orphic doctrine of reincarnation and enlightenment, and provides Vali with a map of the Underworld of the sort found in Orphic graves from late antiquity.

By secret paths known only to the Forest folk, Hanuman led the brothers away from the rocky outcrop into a dense wood. Sugriva and his attendants followed timidly, still overcome with fear of Vali. Before long they came to a green wall, all interlocked ferns and branches, thorns sticking outward. “The city walls”, said Hanuman; and the wall unfurled before them like so many fern leaves, revealing the way to a city unlike any Rama or Lakshman had ever seen.

Kishkindha was built of no stones, no brickwork, not even painted wood. Instead, the city towered above them as a hive of dwellings made of vines and tangled branches like the nests of weaver birds. The streets of Kishkindha were root bridges suspended one above the other between the trees; its lights were fireflies and glow worms dangling from thorns. This truly was a city of the wild Forest. Dionysos-Rama looked upon it in wonder, and smiled.

Presently a great clamour broke out among the city’s monkey denizens from within its dark depths. A warriors stepped forward, tall and imposing, wearing a red mantle and bearing a golden thyrsus as a scepter. Sugriva gave a cry and hid behind the nearest tree, while the warrior addressed Dionysos-Rama directly.

“Lord Bromius, I have heard of Your return to the mortal Universe. I am honoured to welcome You to Kishkindha my city. I am Vali, ruler over the monkey people of the Forest, Your maenads of old.”

“And what a welcome it is, Vali,” answered Dionysos-Rama, “but tell Me... is it true that you betrayed your brother and drove him from your city?”

“I see that Sugriva has tried to win Your favour against me, Lord Evius. I can see him plainly, hiding behind his tree like a mouse. But Sugriva is a liar and a fool. It was he who betrayed me! The Dandaka Forest, on whose edge we live, is home to many an ancient monster from the days when the Titans still walked the earth. One day, my brother and I entered the Forest to hunt one such monster. We found the cave where the monster lived. We decided it would be wise for one of us to stay outside and keep watch, in case the creature had help, and so we cast lots; and the lot fell on me to enter the cave, and on Sugriva to stay behind.

“That cave was a twisting labyrinth, far larger inside than out. It took me twelve days of searching in total darkness to even find the beast, and another seven to slay it. When I finally made my way back, the cavern floor flowed red with the creature’s blood. But what did I find at the cave mouth but a stone rolled in front of the entrance, and Sugriva gone, having left me for dead!

“With great effort, I rolled the stone from the entrance and returned to my city. There, a further surprise awaited me: my brother, seated comfortably on my throne, having taken my wife and my palace, and having convinced the entire city that I was dead and that he was my heir.

“Sugriva never kept watch at all, Lord Bromius. The moment I entered the cave, he rolled that stone before my exit hoping to trap me there, then ran back to Kishkindha to install himself on my throne and force himself upon Tara, my wife. For Sugriva has long desired both the woman and the Kingship, but was too weak for either; and so he tried to take by trickery what was never his by right. This is why I banished him from my city.”

“Please listen to me, o Lord!” cried Sugriva, as he ran from his hiding place and threw himself down at Dionysos-Rama’s feet. “I did follow my brother to that cavern, and I did roll the stone I front of the entrance. But I am no traitor!

“I waited before the cave mouth for many days. On the twelfth day I saw blood run from the entrance in a thick red river, and I feared Vali was dead. And since the monster, enraged at being disturbed, might rush out and follow me to Kishkindha, I rolled a heavy stone in front of the cave, to prevent its exit. I returned to my city in tears, Lord Bromius, and I took up the Kingship only because I did not want to leave Kishkindha leaderless, prey to robbers and enemies. As for Tara, I wanted only to comfort her in her grief.”

The people of Kishkindha had all swung down from their branches and root bridges, and demanded that Dionysos-Rama sit in judgement between the brothers. But Tara, Vali’s wife, was known throughout the land for her pure wisdom, keen intelligence, and deep love for her husband. She took Vali aside and advised him.

“Listen to me, Vali. You know Who this Rama is. You yourself addressed Him as Lord Bromius, Evius, Dionysos. But remember what sort of god He is. Pentheus of Thebes was strong and honourable; yet when he set himself against the god he ended a corpse, gnawed by wild women. King Midas of Phrygia underestimated the sheer power of Dionysos’ blessings; and he nearly died of hunger and thirst in the midst of all the riches of the world. The ways of gods are not the ways of men.

“My love, it is clear that Sugriva has made an ally of the god. Look at the devotion he shows! That is why he suddenly found the courage to come here. Please, Vali, take my advice and make peace with both Sugriva and the god. Do not oppose Dionysos; for I cannot bear to see you die like Pentheus and then to live at Sugriva’s mercy.”

But Vali, for all his strength and virtue, was also proud and arrogant. He only laughed at his wife and said, “Why do you worry so? Lord Bromius has no reason to harm me. As for Sugriva, he is a coward and a fool. He is no match for me. In a contest between us, a just god cannot help but choose my side.”

So saying, Vali went out to meet his brother and his god. But Dionysos-Rama remembered Lakheisis' oracle; how the Moira had named Sugriva, not Vali, as His chief maenad and the leader of His armies. And so, inclining His head at Sugriva in a gesture of silent recognition, Dionysos-Rama took His bow and loosed an arrow at Vali's heart, in secret, out of sight of all.

Vali fell like a great tree felled by an axe, and at once the skies above Kishkindha darkened. Silence descended over all, until Vali's rasping, halting breath was all that could be heard, and even Sugriva stood in awe and terror.

Dionysos-Rama unstrung His bow and approached the dying Vali. Vali's eyes flew open, and he cast a look of bitter recrimination at the god. "How did You shoot me down from hiding, like a mere beast? I had no quarrel with You. I did not banish You from my city, like Pentheus. I did not ask You for a foolish boon, like Midas. Yet You never even sat in judgement between my brother and I like my people asked of You. Instead You murdered me, from hiding, like a coward.

"You are the Universal Spirit, o Dionysos! All the peoples of the world strive for You: the philosophers teach only Your wisdom, the poets sing only in approximation of Your beauty and Your truth. Tara my wife warned me not to trust You, warned me not to face You. But I laughed at her, Lord Bromius. I laughed at her for surely the Ultimate Good, Truth incarnate upon the earth as a noble warrior Prince, would not do injustice against me. Oh, how wrong I was to trust You. How could You embody such Good, such Virtue, such Beauty, yet commit such evil?"

For a long moment Dionysos-Rama stood there, staring down at the fallen Vali. No one spoke; not a sound could be heard. Then the god spoke to Vali. "Vali, you do not understand the Universe.

"This world you are leaving is mere illusion, Vali; this body of yours which I broke is nothing like what you are. You are a divine spirit, a sliver of starlight, a piece of Myself, the Universal, mixed with the earthly ashes of the Titans. You have lived billions of lives, Vali; and I have seen them all. But at the end of each life, mortals travel to the far shore of the Styx, where they are struck with great thirst. 'Give me water to drink, urgently!' you say to those who receive you in the House of Persephone, and you are given water from the River Lethe, who makes men forget all their troubles, and all their lives. This is why none of you can remember your previous lives; and so you forget all their lessons, and remain trapped in the endless cycle of rebirth, never reuniting with the Ultimate. Thus, the Titans remain victorious.

"But take comfort, Vali! I am not so merciless as you suppose. For in the House of Persephone are many rooms, many fountains besides Lethe; and I Dionysos am also Hades. I give you a map to take with you on your journey. It will lead you to Mnemosyne, the Well of Memory, where you will remember all the lessons your soul has learned. Then you shall reunite with the Ultimate, Vali; you will overcome the evil of the Titans that separated you from your true nature, and you need never be reborn into this world of suffering again.

"You are a child of earth and starry sky, Vali. I have not destroyed you; I have set you free."

And Dionysos-Rama took from His fawnskins a small tablet of lapis lazuli inscribed with a map of the Underworld, and gave it to Vali. And along with the god's gift came His blessing; so that Vali was filled, heart and mind and soul, with divine light and divine joy. And so he died, with the love of Dionysos in his heart, and the image of Dionysos in his eyes.

Suddenly the silence was broken by a loud wailing, many voices keening in unison. Tara, Vali's Queen, came out from her palace, followed by her women and Angada her son. She threw herself across Vali's body and wept, the women wailing around her, her son beside her on the ground.

"O Vali my love, why didn't you listen to my warning! Why didn't you listen to the ancient poets who spoke of Dionysos and how He treats those who oppose Him? How could this have happened to you, you who were never defeated in battle? How could you leave me, Vali, and your son, to the mercy of that fratricide Sugriva, coward that he is?"

Tara looked up from her wailing to cast a hateful glance at Sugriva. "How happy you must be," she spat at him, "how happy you must be with your new Kingdom, your city, your harem of women, and all of it yours alone! How easy it must be for you to sleep now, Sugriva, now there is no one left to take it from you. But you have committed a great sacrilege today, my dear brother-in-law. You have murdered your brother and enlisted Lord Bromius Himself to aid you. May the Kindly Ones, who care for the widows and orphans of murder victims, find you, Sugriva. May they repay you for the evil you did today."

And Sugriva wept in shame, all enmity with his brother forgotten; but Tara did not look at him again. Instead, she turned to Dionysos-Rama and said, "Lord Dionysos, You are known to be gentle to mortals. Have mercy on me then, and on my son. Kill us with the same arrow that killed my husband. Send us to the Gates of Hades, so that Vali shall not be alone; and so that Sugriva shall not do with us as he pleases."

But Dionysos-Rama only smiled gently at the grieving woman. "Lady, I commend your love and your loyalty. But all things in the Universe happen by the fickle hand of Fate alone. It was Fate that brought Me to Kishkindha; Fate that brought Vali to his death and his deliverance; and it is not your Fate to die today. Even the gods are bound to the Moirai's Thread. You shall live, Tara, and your son shall be King of this city one day. This is My oracle to you."

Then the god turned to the quivering, weeping Sugriva and said, "Sugriva, I command you to behave in a way worthy of a King. You must cease your weeping, put aside your shame, and show grace to your people, your nephew, and your sister-in-law. Show Tara the honour she deserves as a great Queen, and love Angada as you would your own son; for both are your brother's blood.

"And always remember that your people are My maenads, Sugriva, that you hold your Kingship by a god's grace. Then I shall give you My blessing, and turn away the anger of the Furies."

Sugriva assented; and Lakshman set about building a funeral pyre for Vali, while Tara's women led their queen back into her palace. But Angada, grown up years in a single day, stood quiet at his uncle's side.

Seven days did the people of Kishkindha hold funeral games for Vali, their former King. As maenads of Dionysos, their contests were of poetry and song, theatre and music, lyre, pipes, and flute. And once the seven days were up, Dionysos-Rama and Lakshman left Kishkindha, to wait for Sugriva to come follow them and lead them to Sita, to Ravana, to Fate.

And Lakshman, alone once more with his brother in a cabin in the Forest, wept in secret for the kind and loving Rama he had lost to the exalted god. For Rama now fast approached his destiny; and the Spirit of Dionysos had totally overcome him, so that Lakshman no longer recognized his brother.

Dionysos is seductive and savage, gentle and terrifying; and Lakshman, remembering Khara and Vali, Pentheus and Midas, knew better than to oppose Him.

The Waiting

Chapter Summary

Sugriva, having won the Kingship of Kishkindha with the aid of Dionysos-Rama, gives himself up to pleasure and debauchery. Only Tara, his wise sister-in-law, is able to save both him and his city from the god's wrath.

And so Sugriva became king of Kishkindha. At first he was afraid, still ashamed and grieving for his brother, still half expecting the Furies to carry him off. But after several weeks of peace, with no sign of enmity from either Tara or the gods, Sugriva grew complacent.

He withdrew to his palace, where he spent all his time in his women's quarters, steeped in a continuous feast of women and wine. He soon tired of his own wife, Ruma, and took more and more girls to his bed; and finally, in a drunken haze, summoned even Tara to come to him. And however much his advisers tried to reach him, to warn him, Sugriva would listen to no one.

All this time Dionysos-Rama lived with His brother in a woodland cave in the wild Forest, outside the city walls. Lakshesis' oracle had been clear; yet the days became weeks, the weeks became months, and still no sign of Sugriva and his maenads, still no army to follow its god to Lanka. When the rains came to Kishkindha, the Forest paths flooded; and travel became quite impossible.

Lakshman was the first to lose his temper. "We should have spared Vali and killed this treacherous fool instead! We were wrong ever to trust a man who stands ready to kill his own brother. A god came to his aid, and look how he repays the honour! Rama, Sugriva has betrayed you. All he wanted was his Kingdom back; now that he has it, he's quite forgotten us both. I doubt he ever knew how to help us find Sita. Let's go to Kishkindha, Rama, and make that traitor pay! Let Tara rule as Queen until Angada comes of age; and let all the world know what happens to those who would betray the gods."

But Dionysos-Rama held up a hand and said, "A true initiate knows the proper time for frenzy and the proper time for calm. Go to the city without violence first, as Dionysos came to Thebes with kindness. Ask Sugriva again for his help, and remind him of his promise. Tell him that wine and pleasure are indeed My province; but that a god's friendship is not a thing to be taken lightly. Remind Sugriva that the portal through which his brother left this world is still open."

But Lakshman was mortal, not divine. A boiling storm filled his heart: his love for his brother, his devotion to his god, his grief at losing Rama to the burning divine Spirit, and his anger at Sugriva's betrayal all vied for dominance within Lakshman's soul. And so he

marched on Kishkindha with bow drawn and fire in his eyes. The look of him so terrified the monkeys who guarded the walls that they fled screaming to Sugriva's apartments.

A throng of citizens had already gathered at the base of the great tree across whose branches Kishkindha's palace spread. They had come with petitions, emergencies, pleas; and the arrival of the fleeing guards sent them into a panic. The city desperately cried out for leadership; but of Sugriva, there was no sign.

Instead, the monkey King hid himself away in his women's quarters, half asleep with wine and pleasure. "What's all the fuss about?" he asked; and Tara, his brother's wife, who was the only one there still sober, said, "Lakshman has come to our city determined to destroy you, and us with you. Go to him, please, rouse yourself and fulfill your promise to the god. You must lead your people to Lanka behind Dionysos, Sugriva, or we shall all be lost."

But Sugriva shook with terror at the prospect of facing Lakshman and said, "Woman, I fear neither Rama nor his brother! They cannot force themselves on me, after I have lived so long deprived of the comforts of my city and my throne. You go speak to this warrior. I am not going out there."

By now, Lakshman had made his way into Sugriva's palace, unchallenged by the terrified, chattering monkeys around him. His weapons drawn, he seemed a thundercloud descended upon the city at midday. He met Tara, alone, on a balcony of woven branches outside Sugriva's rooms.

"I see Sugriva has stooped so low as to send a woman to seduce me," Lakshman said upon seeing Tara. "Does he think I am like him, fickle and interested only in pleasure? Does he think I, too, will betray my brother and my god the moment I am given some shiny bauble? Out of my way, woman; I shall make Sugriva pay for his treachery."

Tara considered her words carefully. "O warrior, not even the gods are spared from Eros' arrows. What then of a simple monkey? We monkey-folk are like the Satyrs of Phrygia; we are creatures of feeling, not philosophy, and we live simple lives in the moment.

"Please understand. Sugriva had been denied pleasure for so long, living in the stony places. You and I both know he is no paragon of virtue. He could not help himself. Sugriva has sunk so deep in his morass of indulgence, he has forgotten even the governance of his Kingdom.

"But surely the Satyrs are no different? Surely they too, creatures of the wild as we are, spend their time drinking and dancing, and have little understanding of cities or the ways of Kings? Yet our Lord Dionysos loves them no less. Sugriva never meant to hurt you or Lord Bromius. We both know that the god can be gentle and forgiving. Sugriva, and we folk of Kishkindha have not forgotten His friendship. Please, let Lord Dionysos forgive His imperfect friend."

Lakshman made no reply; but Tara saw that the fire in his eyes had dimmed. Taking courage, she gave her final argument. "O warrior, you should also know that even in his drunken stupor, Sugriva has not been entirely idle. He has sent for his people outside the city to gather here in a great host, and they are already on their way. Your brother shall have a magnificent army to lead to His battle of destiny."

Lakshman gave a start at this news, and the vengeful flame in his heart went out. Tara smiled as she saw her son and her home saved from the god's wrath, though she had to hide her own involvement and credit Sugriva with the summons she herself had sent in secret. She stretched out her hand to Lakshman and said, "Come, warrior, see Sugriva for yourself and be reassured that I am no false temptress."

So saying, Tara led Lakshman through a dark maze of wooden corridors in the heart of the great tree. They came to the women's palace; but to Tara's dismay, Sugriva lay sprawled on gold-embroidered cushions, surrounded by Ruma and three other women as inebriated as himself. A smell of wine filled the air, and amphorae lay overturned across the floor.

Lakshman's eyes blazed anew as he said, "Is this how your King repays his friends? A compassionate King wins renown among men. A valiant King is made immortal in the songs of poets. But one as dissolute and ungrateful as you are, Sugriva, does not deserve his throne. I will return to the Forest; and you shall die by the arrow that killed your brother."

Sugriva could only whimper and look to Tara, who, cursing his debauchery in her heart, quickly intervened. "Please, do not be angry at what you see. Didn't I tell you that Sugriva is only a monkey, that he cannot help himself? He truly means you no harm, Lakshman! In fact, Sugriva speaks of Rama and what He has done for him day and night! Do not doubt our devotion only because you do not understand our ways."

Sugriva had recovered himself enough to make a defense, and so rose from his cushions and addressed Lakshman, hands folded in contrition. "You are right, my lord, I have sinned in waiting. But I have not forgotten you! It is as Tara my Queen says. I fell helplessly to pleasure, and lost track of time. But did we not swear friendship? Did I not meet my god in the flesh once again, after so many lifetimes? Of course I have not forgotten you. My armies and I shall join Lord Dionysos dancing, as soon as they arrive."

As if summoned by those words, the sound of trumpets and the clamour of a marching army rang out. Lakshman, Sugriva, and Tara, their quarrel forgotten, rushed out onto the balcony and looked down at phalanxes of monkeys marching into Kishkindha, colourful pennants waving in the air, the song of a thousand pipes accompanying them. Dionysos' maenad army, so long parted from their god, had arrived.

Icaros

Chapter Summary

Faced with the might of the Ocean, which has terrified heroes from Gilgamesh to Odysseus, the maenad army of Kishkindha loses hope of ever finding Lanka. Even Dionysos, His divine vision limited by His mortal incarnation, cannot see across the expanse that divides Ravana's island from India. But Icaros son of Daedalos, his wings long since burned away by the sun, uses his one remaining divine blessing to seek out Lanka across the waves.

Once more, a Bacchic horde danced across India, Dionysos followed by His maenads in a procession of song and celebration. Once more, Phrygian pipes and Thracian lyres mingled with the song of the Indian vina in a single melody. Once more, the song of Orpheus enchanted the land, bringing deliverance to all who heard it and danced.

And once more, Dionysos, the Universal Spirit incarnate upon the earth again and again, marched inexorably to His destiny. The mountains and the trees and the beasts of the earth all sang with Him, all yearning for Ravana to meet his Fate, to be set free.

They danced through meadows and forests, across mountains and rivers, past glimmering cities and great old trees. Finally they reached the edge of that great land. Forest gave way to sandy beach, while before them stretched out an azure sea, unbroken by land all the way to the far horizon. There was no way across it and no way around it, for the sea stretched in every direction except the one from which the maenads had come.

Waves tall as whole ships came crashing to that shore; and the maenads, who being Forest folk knew nothing of the Ocean, recoiled chattering in terror. Even Lakshman felt afraid, for this great sea seemed so much more threatening than even the widest river.

“How shall we ever find Lanka now?” the maenads cried out to their god. “This is the Ocean that encircles the earth; beyond it there is nothing but Chaos! How could Sita be there?”

But gentle Dionysos-Rama smiled indulgently at His fearful maenads. “Once, among the Cretans, there was a divine artificer named Daedalos. Hephaistos had given him a blessing: that whatever his mind could imagine, his hands could build. And Daedalos built all the wonders of the ancient world: great cities made entirely of glass and precious stone; automata that spoke and walked and opened temple doors; great Labyrinths where the Cretan bull-god stalked.

“Now Daedalos had a son named Icaros, whom he loved dearly. One day, after Theseus of Athens had escaped the Labyrinth and brought low the glory of King Minos, the King suspected Daedalos and his son of plotting against him; and so imprisoned them both within

the Labyrinth. But Daedalos in his mind called up an image of two sets of wings, made of beeswax and flax; and with these, he and his son escaped King Minos' wrath.

“Daedalos and Icaros flew far away from Crete, towards the rising sun. Daedalos was careful; but Icaros, delighted at his new ability to fly, rose higher and higher. Daedalos tried to warn him, to call out to him; but soon, Icaros flew so high in the sky he had gone beyond the clouds, and could neither hear nor see his father.

“Finally, the sun began to sting Icaros' back, and Helios cried out to him, ‘Take care! Go down, or you will fall!’ But Icaros did not listen. He flew straight towards the Sun Himself. And so his wings burned away to ashes and dust, and he fell from the sky.

“My maenads, the land Icaros fell upon is this one. He inherited from his divine father exceptional powers of vision and prophecy. He will tell us where Lanka is, and how to cross the Ocean.”

Dionysos-Rama turned away from the beach towards a line of sandy cliffs, scraggly thickets growing on their tops. In a loud voice He cried out, “Icaros son of Daedalos! Come out and show yourself!” A rustling sound came out from those dunes, and out sprung a giant eagle, larger than any elephant. He jumped down from the sandy ridge and landed at the god's feet.

Icaros had once been magnificent to look upon, and his former beauty could still be seen. His eagle feathers were a faded gold, its sparkle gone, erased by his great age. Bald patches dotted his body, and his wings were two burned stumps, still blackened from the sun-god's fire.

“Here I am, Lord Bromius,” said Icaros. “What would You ask of me? As you see, I can no longer fly.”

“Son of Daedalos, it is true that Helios took your wings. But you had other blessings. My maenads fear the Ocean, and do not believe they will ever see the isle of Lanka. I Myself wear mortal flesh, and cannot see across the waves. Will you use your eagle's sight to tell us where Sita is?”

Icaros rose and stood at the edge of the water. Waving the maenads out of his way, he peered across the sea. None in that great army saw anything but the blue Ocean; but suddenly Icaros cried out, “I see it! I see Lanka, the City my father built of lapis and carnelian. I see the Labyrinth, that great wonder at its heart, like a spear pointing upwards to the sky. And at the heart of the Labyrinth, in a garden of blooming flowers, yes, I see Sita.”

Great rejoicing broke out among the maenads, and soon Icaros was bedecked with garlands and gold. Dionysos-Rama danced among them, showering His maenads with blessings. From that day on, all in that army had the power to change their form, as the rakshasas did, and possessed strength greater than that of elephants.

But Icaros again fell at the god's feet and said, “Lord Bromius, when I fell from the sky, Zeus cursed me for my hubris. I was made immortal but not ageless, doomed to live forever in infirmity. Please, o Evius, show me mercy by letting me die.”

And Dionysos, Who knows the secret paths out of the suffering of the Universe, granted Icaros his final wish.

Theseus Goes To Crete

Chapter Summary

Hanuman crosses the sea to Lanka, meeting Scylla and Charybdis on his way. In a confrontation at the gates, he fulfills the oracle given to Lankini by Clotho, Spinner of Fate.

Seven days and seven nights did the maenads sing and dance for the shade of Icaros. After the funeral games had passed, all were eager to make their move on the City of Ravana. Once again, Dionysos marched in India; His maenads an army that carried His frenzy and His song. But Dionysos-Rama held up His hand and said, “Maenads and Satyrs! I commend your devotion; but no general sends his army into battle without first knowing the terrain and his enemy’s defenses. One of your number must scout ahead.”

But the maenads were forest folk, and the sea was a new sight to them. They quaked in terror at the crashing waves, their erstwhile enthusiasm all forgotten. “How shall we cross this Ocean?” they cried out. “We are monkeys and bears; we have neither ships nor wings.” At a distance from the others, hugging his knees on a bare rock, sat a young man in the god’s great army. Hanuman was the son of Aeolus the Wind, and his divine father had promised to carry him on the air wherever he wished to go. But Hanuman was a humble youth, and Aeolus’ youngest son; and he was unsure of himself. He peered into the distance longingly; but his doubts stopped him whenever he tried to leap.

Lakshman noticed the young maenad and said to Angada, Vali’s son, “Who is that shy youth there, on a rock all by himself?”

“That is Hanuman,” answered Angada, “he is the son of Aeolus the Wind, but is too humble to believe it.”

Lakshman went over to Hanuman on his perch. “You are in the presence of Rama, whom men call Dionysos, Bromius, and Evius. He is the Universal Spirit Itself, incarnate upon the earth. Even I was afraid, when I first followed Him into the Forest. But His light took all my fears away. You too, Hanuman, need not fear. Dionysos-Rama will give you all the power you need.”

But still Hanuman doubted himself; so that old Sugriva, seeing him, came to his rock and said, “In the old days, long ago, there was a young hero much like yourself. He, too, was the son of a god; and he, too, doubted himself, since he was no more than a boy, yet called upon to free his people from an evil King. His name was Theseus.

“Theseus was no warrior; so he boarded a Cretan ship as a slave, to be taken to Crete as tribute. But there his true nature revealed itself: for this young boy brought down the evil

ruler of Daedalos' first Labyrinth, King Minos of Crete. Hanuman, Theseus acted because the Fates called him to it. Likewise you, too, are called. Do not tarry. I know you can find a way across this Ocean."

Sugriva's tale inspired Hanuman, and he took courage. Climbing onto the same sandy ridge from which Icaros had emerged, he leapt into the air. Aeolus his father took hold of him, and within moments he was carried far beyond the maenads' sight.

Hanuman flew high in the air. He no longer saw the beach behind him; nor did he glimpse the isle of Lanka ahead of him. Suddenly the current of that sea was drawn all to a single place, as if entering a great funnel. When he saw two sheer rocks looming up ahead, Hanuman rejoiced, sure to have found Lanka. But Aeolus his father warned him, saying, "Beware those rocks! They are no islands, but great mountains which Ravana has brought here from the far lands of the Yavana to guard his shores. Each one harbours a terrible monster.

"The mountain on the right looks beautiful, clouds gathered at its summit and its surface polished as a mirror. At its base lies a cave, and in that cave lives Scylla. Day and night she calls out; her voice is seductive, a sweet woman's song. But even the gods fear her. Twelve legs she has, each clawed like a tiger's; and six heads with gaping mouths, three rows of teeth in each.

"The mountain on the left looks friendly; a grove of fig trees grows upon it that bear fruit throughout the year. But at its base, hidden beneath the sea, lives the ancient goddess Charybdis. Greedily she gulps down water; but when she sees her prey flying through the air, she spurts it back up to catch her victims. She is the cause of the funnel of water and the reason why there are no birds in these skies.

"Avoid Charybdis, my son; for not even I could save you from her waters. But fly close to Scylla's mountain; I will carry you above the reach of her teeth." And so Hanuman flew close to Scylla's mountain. Six gaping mouths snapped at his feet on necks so long they reached up into the sky. But Aeolus carried his son safely out of Scylla's reach, up and away across the waves; before setting him down, gently, on a fragrant green shore.

Hanuman reached Lanka's shores at sunset. How different this strange island was from Icaros' beach, or even from leafy Kishkindha! Lanka's beach was a profusion of flowers of every colour, strange flowers from the world before Deukalion's Flood; and green herbs grew everywhere in a soft carpet. Flower petals fell from the sky onto Hanuman's head, carried by the wind from some unknown source; and the salty spray of the sea mingled with the scents of the flowers and herbs into a heady fragrance.

A short distance away stood a massive gate, glazed all over in lapis blue, golden bulls stamped onto its brickwork. A series of painted columns, each surmounted by a golden bull's head, led up to it. It all sparkled in the light of the setting sun like fire, and Hanuman felt himself drawn to it in rapt amazement. Only the birds of the air raised their voices at Lanka's Gate. No man stood there, no warrior, no sentry. Only a woman, a goddess dark as twilight and fearsome as Night herself, barred Hanuman's way. Hanuman did not recognize her; but she knew him instantly, for the Spinner of Fate had once foretold her his coming in an oracle.

She stepped forward and said to Hanuman, "I am Lankini, Spirit of the City of Lanka. In ages past, Daedalos, Architect of the Gods, bade me stand here to guard his greatest work, his Second Labyrinth. And for centuries, I have stood undefeated. But one evening, at a dusk like this one, Clotho, Spinner of Fate, came to my Gate. She gave me an oracle: that one day, a little monkey would come to Lanka, to strike me down, to cut my Thread. And see, here he stands before me. Strike then, maenad of Lord Bacchus. For none can thwart the Fates."

Hanuman understood and answered, "Great Lady, I have come here flying through the air like the birds, by the power of a god. I have seen the mountainous monsters that Ravana bound to his island, and they could do me no harm. I have marched and danced to Dionysos' music. The god's will shall be done."

So saying, he took his mace, wound round with ivy like a thyrsus, and struck Lankini down so that she lay prostrate at his feet. Tears streamed down her face as she wept for her City and her King, and for Daedalos her father whose last wonder would now be destroyed.

"Speak well of me to Lord Bromius, o maenad," she said. "Ask Him to guide my soul across the Styx, out of rebirth, out of suffering."

And the last act of Lankini was to open her Gates, to welcome her destroyer.

Ariadne

Chapter Summary

Hanuman wanders Lanka at night and soon finds himself lost in its Labyrinth. He only finds Sita at sunrise, in the midst of a confrontation with Ravana that has Ravana play the role of Pentheus from the start of the *Bacchae*, including many of Pentheus' lines taken from Euripides. The madness of Dionysos becomes apparent in him; and it is clear even to Ravana's own people what his fate will be.

Lanka was a wonder of the ancient world, a great City of the Heroic Age. At nightfall, it was a marvel to behold. The City stretched across a central hill in a cascade of painted brickwork, alabaster windows, and streets paved with lapis and carnelian. Gardens dotted the landscape, and between the murmur of fountains, music and song could be heard from all directions. The air was fragrant with a thousand flowers and a thousand cooking fires. The streets were crowded, all the citizens out seeking pleasure in the gardens and palaces as though at a festival.

Hanuman marveled at it all, the strange and exotic citizens chief among the City's wonders. Never before had he seen such a crowd, of people who seemed to come from the very ends of the earth. Dusky rakshasas mingled with Egyptians, blue-painted Gauls and Thracians, dark Nubians and Indians, and a great many Cretans in pleated skirts. No one even noticed Hanuman among the throng. Chants, songs, and merchants' cries rang out in a dozen tongues.

Towering above it all stood the greatest Wonder of the World: the Second Labyrinth, a sheer multilayered tower pointing at the sky like the tip of a great stone spear, two brazen bull's horns at the top gleaming in the twilight sun. Hanuman was drawn to it inexorably, certain to find Sita within; but the Labyrinth was a House of Many Rooms, its every level a warren of gardens, halls and courtyards. Soon, Hanuman found himself quite lost.

Room after room he wandered through as the night wore on: a blur of painted columns, tiled halls, baths whose silver pipes ran with clear water from hot springs, and bull-headed golden thrones. Outside, he saw gardens, sacred bulls softly bellowing in their pens, an armoury where the Labrys, the sacred axe, was kept in a tended shrine, and the women's palace, which he hastened past with averted eyes. Hanuman began to despair of ever finding Sita. At the end of yet another long corridor he came to a door all of beaten gold. Behind it lay a shadowy room, redolent of incense burning in a single brazier. In the centre stood a great bed of cedar wood inlaid with ivory and Cretan pearls, flanked by two golden bulls whose eyes were a lifelike lapis.

Hanuman's own eyes widened; for in this bed lay a great rakshasa lord who could surely be none other than Ravana himself. His skin was dark, his features calm and regal, radiating pride and power. Neatly wound black curls framed his face. Beside him lay a woman with

pale golden skin who shone like the moon, and for a moment Hanuman's very life left him; for surely this was Sita, lying peacefully in Ravana's bed of her own choice. But he soon recovered himself. For this lady's hair sported locks of silver, and her face showed lines of age; whereas Sita had been young as the new spring.

Quickly leaving that chamber by another door, Hanuman found himself beside a fountain, on a balcony overlooking the City far below. He had refreshed himself with the cool water when a woman approached him, a tall woman with the golden hair and blue tattoos of a Thracian lady.

"Welcome to our City, blessed Bacchant," she said. "I noticed your ivy-wrapped mace down in the gardens. But tell me: what brings you to Lanka? And why do you wander alone through the Labyrinth, rather than introduce yourself? What are you looking for?"

"I carry my mace in honour of Lord Dionysos, my god," answered Hanuman, "and I am here by the god's command. Lord Dionysos has raised His army of maenads once again; and once again, we march through India dancing behind Him. He marches on Lanka like a whirlwind, for the Fates have driven Him here so that Ravana may face his god.

"Ravana has taken from Lord Dionysos a woman He loves dearly, His wife and first follower. And so the god has sent me ahead of His host, to find her and to offer Ravana His mercy. For by mercy alone may this City's evil fate be averted."

The Thracian woman nodded in understanding. "I am an initiate in the Mysteries myself, as I hail from the homeland of Orpheus," she said. "I honour you, stranger, as fellow Bacchant and devotee of the god. If Ravana has indeed done as you say, he has acted most foolishly; but he is proud and lustful, and his heart may well have overwhelmed his reason.

"I know well Lord Dionysos' mercy. He can be the gentlest to us mortals, when asked. Recently, a woman arrived, with skin like pale gold, clad in the fawnskins of a maenad. She was brought to the garden of ashoka trees that overlooks the Ocean on the western edge of the Labyrinth. If she is the woman you seek, take her back to the god's side; and ask Him to be merciful for my sake, and for the sake of our City."

Dawn had already boarded her chariot in the eastern sky when Hanuman and the Thracian lady reached the ashoka grove. Red blossoms hung in clusters from every branch. Alone, under an overarching branch of an ancient tree, sat Sita. Her face was stained with tears, and she stared ahead of her, unseeing. Then heavy footsteps approached behind, and Hanuman and his Thracian companion hid themselves behind a tree as Ravana, clad in pure ceremonial white, came striding into the grove. Though the god's madness consumed his heart, it did not yet show upon his face; Ravana still held his head high and proud.

"Do not fear me," he said to Sita, "for I have only love for you in my heart. You have lived so long in the Forest, you have forgotten that you are a Princess. This wild life in the woods is beneath you. Forget that god of yours; let the barbarians of the hills and forests have him. I offer you my City, my Kingdom, my very heart and soul. Be my Queen, Sita, and you shall rule the world by my side. All the Kings of the earth pay me tribute, and the gods themselves go in fear of me. Accept me, love me, be mine alone; and you shall have riches and power beyond even the cities of Heaven."

But Sita sat turned away, and did not even look at Ravana as she answered him. "I belong to my Lord alone. You are a fool and a blasphemer; your riches and power are nothing."

Ravana began to lose his temper, the madness laying hold of his mind, raw lust flashing in his eyes. "You're a bold one, to deny me, Lord of the Greatest City in the World!"

"Really? What will you do to me, then, with all that awesome power of yours? Go on, tell me!"

"Cut off your nose and ears, for a start. That way, not even your god will want you back in his grove."

She faced him now, smiling broadly at his maddened eyes, Hanuman and the Thracian lady frozen in terror and fascination behind the tree under which she sat. "Try it, then. You can't bring yourself to. He won't let you."

"Curse that god of yours, woman! He's not worthy of the name! He's no more than a wild man from the forest. And where is he now, your saviour? I don't see him!"

"This very moment He knows I am here," answered Sita, retaining perfect serenity in the face of Ravana's madness, "He knows how I suffer. No, Ravana, you will do nothing to me. I have control of my senses; you have not."

Ravana visibly wavered, unsure whether to turn from her in horror or run towards her in love, his reason locked in combat with relentless Bacchic frenzy. "You accursed woman! Even before I ever laid eyes on you, your face filled my dreams, my thoughts. What curse, what evil spell have you cast over me?"

"I have done nothing to you, you impious fool. You have made yourself a god's enemy, in your mindless pride. Now you bear His madness without His blessing; and you shall end a mad wretch, torn on the hillside by wild beasts and wild women."

Ravana could bear it no longer; quick as lightning, he drew his sword and held its point a hair's width from Sita's throat. But though he shook all over with the effort of it, he could go no further. He dropped the sword and collapsed sobbing at Sita's feet, clasping her knees as a suppliant does.

"I wish I had a voice in my arms and hands and hair," he said, pleading with Sita, "in the feet on which I walk, whether by the art of Daedalos or the help of the gods, so they could all cry out together to please relent, be mine. O Light of the World, without you my life is as nothing, the dawn over Lanka brings no light to my eyes."

But Sita looked down, as impervious to Ravana's pleading as she had been to his threats, and said, "I pity you, poor fool. But I belong to Lord Bromius alone. Your own hubris and impiety have condemned you."

So saying, she shook his hands from round her knees and rose to go, leaving Ravana prostrate on the ground behind her. Finally he, too, gathered himself up and walked away, all life gone

from his eyes. When Hanuman dared to move, he saw the horror on the Thracian woman's face as her eyes stared unseeing into the distance, unable even to weep.

“You’re an initiate of the god,” he said to her. “You know what this means. He has set himself against Lord Dionysos; there is only one fate left to him. Go into your house, woman, rend your garments, pour ashes on your hair; for your City and your King are soon to be destroyed.”

And so the Thracian lady turned away from the ashoka grove, back into the Labyrinth, back into her City which she now understood was doomed.

The Fires Of Hephaistos

Chapter Summary

Hanuman lays waste to Lanka as the fires of Thera did to Crete, and has an exchange with Ravana that mirrors Dionysos' exchange with Pentheus from the Bacchae.

Sail back to Athens with black sails, Theseus.

Finally, Hanuman found himself face to face with Sita. She had refused to surrender her thyrsus and still looked like a Bacchant. Spurning the fine silks offered her by Ravana's women, Sita still wore the fawnskins of the Forest, making her a strange sight indeed; a virtuous ascetic in the midst of that ostentatious garden.

The moment she cast her eyes on him, Hanuman felt overwhelmed by love. For this great Princess, he would lay down his life, he would uproot whole forests, he would gladly face an army all alone and without fear. As he stood gazing at Sita, the holy frenzy of Bacchus began to grow within Hanuman's heart; and with it came the blessings which the god had conferred upon His maenads.

No small monkey any longer, Hanuman grew tall as the ashoka trees around him. With more than mortal strength he took hold of a blossoming tree and uprooted it whole, as a child picks a flower. Overcome with joy and love Hanuman danced through the grove, swinging his tree like a thyrsus and singing Bacchus' name. "Have no fear, o goddess!" he cried down to Sita. "These walls cannot hold you. You shall be free!"

Ravana's women, whom he had placed around Sita to guard and to convince her to accept his love, all fled in terror. They ran screaming back to their lord and cried, "A monstrous beast of the Forest has broken into our City and is destroying our gardens! Please help us!"

And Ravana sent companies of warriors; but not one returned.

And Ravana sent bold champions; but they were struck as though by Zeus' thunderbolt, only their ashes left upon the earth.

And Ravana sent the sons of his generals, each one the equal of a thousand warriors; but no blood was drawn by their pointed spears, while Hanuman, hurling whole trees from his hands, inflicted wounds and made those princes turn and run – wood routing bronze.

Soon, what had once been a garden was reduced to a torn mass of roots and blood, a battlefield bloodier than the walls of Troy. And at its heart, the frenzied Hanuman still dancing around her, stood Sita. Still she stood there, at the eye of the storm, her eyes flowing freely with tears but unable to stop the madness which it was her Fate to cause, unable to quit being the Arrow of Dionysos, the Instrument of Fate.

At last the Bacchic fury left Hanuman. He ceased his dance and returned to his mortal size and strength; so that the rakshasas captured him, and brought him bound before Ravana. Ravana sat in his Cretan courtroom, in the midst of panic and disarray. Young men shouted for blood; old men wept over their slaughtered sons. Ravana himself shook with fury at this savage attack upon his City. His love for Lanka and its people had overwhelmed the madness that grew ever stronger in his mind, granting Ravana a brief respite from the god's wrath.

Ravana remained silent. He sat perfectly composed, the fires of grief and fury under fierce control deep within him. His splendour was like that of Helios at midday: pearls and corals round his arms, gold and lapis round his neck, a crown of electrum upon his head. Two great golden bulls, each with garnet eyes, flanked his throne. Hanuman, bound on the palace floor, found himself unable to tear his eyes from the King of the Labyrinth.

Noble, wise, and terrible were Ravana's eyes, and they searched Hanuman's face curiously; until the maenad felt his very soul being scrutinized. At last, the great King spoke. "Who are you, monkey? Where have you come from? What do you want, that you destroyed my grove and slaughtered my warriors? Are you perhaps one of the Fates in disguise, or were you sent by Hades to foretell my death? Speak, monkey!"

Hanuman indicated that he wished to stand and was helped to his feet. Though overcome with admiration for this great King, he addressed Ravana boldly. "Ravana of Lanka, I am no Moira and no god, but a maenad of the Forest. I have come to your City in the name of my god, Lord Dionysos, to warn you of His power and to offer you His mercy.

"For you have set yourself against Him, o King. You have denied my Lord's divinity, you have suppressed His sacred rites in the Dandaka Forest, and you have taken His wife Sita from Him, desecrating His sacred grove.

"You think that your City walls, your spears of bronze, can protect you from Lord Dionysos' wrath. You do not acknowledge the wildness in your own heart, civilized as you think yourself; you think yourself stronger than the gods. This is why I destroyed your ashoka grove, why I killed your warriors: so that you may know the power of Dionysos, so that you may repent of your enmity with Him and accept His mercy.

"For Dionysos is a god by turns most gentle to mortals, and most terrible."

But not even Ravana could stop the Thread of Fate. He shook with fury, and in a barely controlled voice said to his ministers, "Kill him. Let this monkey's blood flow on the altars of Lanka."

Now Vibheeshana Ravana's brother was at court beside him, and had noticed Hanuman's thyrsus and the banked fires of frenzy in his eyes.

Vibheeshana was a great Orphic sage, an initiate who led a pure life of devotion to the god and to Ravana. He saw the grave danger that Ravana was in and intervened, saying, "Brother, take heed! This monkey is the herald of a god; and to abuse a herald, even one of an enemy, is the greatest of crimes among Kings. You know that. So save yourself from dishonour and from divine vengeance. Let this monkey go."

But Hanuman addressed Vibheeshana and said, "It's no use, wise one! The Fates do as they will. Soon your master will fasten me, the Roaring One's servant, in his snares, and even now he holds my Lady inside his palace. Come down then, Lord Bromius, and crush the arrogance of this murderous man!"

And addressing all the assembled rakshasas in the court, Hanuman cried out, "Be sure, this insolence of yours will be punished by Dionysos. When you wrong me, you wrong Him." Every word Hanuman spoke fed the rage in Ravana's heart, and his mind became clouded, his eyes unfocused. But deep within him lay a last vestige of resistance, the last dying shred of reason fighting the god's madness, protesting Fate. This final spark of sanity asserted itself, and Ravana said, "You are right, my wise brother. I will not kill this messenger. But I must punish him for destroying my grove and slaughtering my people.

"Take fire," Ravana said to the guards who held Hanuman, "and set this monkey's tail alight. Let all see what happens to those who do evil."

And so the rakshasas took fine linen and wrapped it round Hanuman's tail. They dipped it in olive oil and lit it, smoky flames like torchlight. As soon as the flames sprang up, the power of Bacchus engulfed Hanuman. Joyfully he danced through the streets and gardens of Lanka; past houses he went, through fields and orchards, and whatever he touched burst into flame. Soon the flames were everywhere, and the women, children, and old men of Lanka went wailing through the scorched streets.

Smoke darkened the sky, turning midday to midnight. Still Hanuman danced, Dionysos' blessing protecting him from the fire so that the flames did not burn even one hair on his tail. And as once Crete had burned when Hephaistos in his forge on Thera rained down fire from the sky, so one third of Lanka was reduced to ashes.

And in the midst of it all stood Sita, the cause and the instrument of Lanka's destruction, the Arrow lodged deep in Ravana's heart. Untouched by the flames, she sat upon the ashes and wept: for her husband, whom she lost to the terrible god Who had taken His place within Rama's soul; for her home and her happiness which she lost to the dark Forest; for her Fate, which brought to ashes and dust all that she touched.

Hanuman, still gripped by frenzy, came dancing through the destroyed grove. "Come away with me, Princess!" he cried out to Sita. "Let me carry you away from this place!" But Sita refused, saying, "I belong to the god alone, o maenad. None other may touch me, or risk His displeasure. Leave me here on this island; my Lord Himself will set me free."

And so Hanuman was forced to leave Sita to her god, as Theseus did Ariadne. The Dionysiac fury left him; and, his tail extinguished, Hanuman leapt from the walls of the Labyrinth into the air. And Aeolus his father carried him safely across the sea, back to the waiting maenads and their god.

Trijata's Oracle

Chapter Summary

A prophetess relates her vision of Ravana as Pentheus, driven mad by a kind, gentle god.

After Hanuman's even greater destruction of their City, all was in disarray among Ravana's people. But they were resilient, and far stronger than Minos' Cretans; and so the men of Lanka set about rebuilding their homes almost as soon as Hanuman had left. But the women of the City built funeral pyres for their dead sons, their dead husbands, their dead fathers; and after they had bewailed them, they went looking for answers.

They found Sita, still sitting in her ruined garden, and cried out to her, "Vile woman, you are the cause of all this! Ravana may have taken you; but why did our men have to die for his sins? And if you are, as you say, a priestess and devotee of a god, and Ravana committed sacrilege by taking you, why not let your god try himself against Ravana's might? Why summon a monkey servant, whom we did no wrong, to destroy us? Did our brothers and sons come to Kishkindha to make war? Why then do you make war on us?" But Sita could do nothing except exhort them to worship Dionysos, and to trust in His mercy.

Then the women of Lanka stood aside along the ruined garden path, to make way for a venerable old rakshasi. Clad in the white garments of a mourner, the woman approached Sita. The women of Lanka crowded round in clear expectation, for the old woman was a prophetess, one who had Apollo's blessing.

"I am Trijata," she said to Sita. "Once, I was Ravana's lover. But that was many years ago, and Ravana's blessings are greater than mine. He kept his youthful vigour, his noble strength; while I grew old and frail. And so I retired to the temples of the Labyrinth and devoted myself to Loxias. And today he has granted me a vision. Loxias knows well his brother Dionysos' purpose for Lanka.

"I saw Ravana flying in a chariot, higher and higher like Icaros of old. He was clad in gold and silver and shone like the sun at midday. But a thunderbolt flew down from the heavens and struck Ravana down, so that he tumbled from the sky. Then the skies turned red as blood, and I saw Ravana on the ground. Dressed in rags he was; and the rags hung around him like a woman's dress. He giggled like a madman, his reason gone; and a woman with skin like gold took him gently by the hand and led him to a city all of bones and dust. Gently, lovingly, she led him; and sometimes, when I looked at her, she seemed transformed into a god, with long hair and horns like a ram's."

"Did the god also give you the meaning of your dream, o prophetess?" asked Sita.

“He did, Princess,” Trijata replied. “Ravana has angered a god, and his Fate comes for him. The thunderbolt is the god’s wrath, striking Ravana down and inspiring him with a deadly madness. The rags he wore are a shroud for the dead, and the city of bones and dust is Hades. And the woman, Sita, the Instrument of Ravana’s Fate, the woman who is also a god... that woman is you. You are the god’s Arrow, come to strike down Ravana from the glorious skies.”

And with those words Trijata veiled her face and left the ruined garden; and the women of Lanka dispersed after her.

Vibheeshana

Chapter Summary

Vibheeshana, Ravana's virtuous brother, is himself overcome with the madness of Dionysos. Hearing only his god's voice, seeing only his god's face, he throws aside virtue and caution and betrays his brother and his people, rushing helplessly into Dionysos' arms.

At several points while reading my Indian source, I found myself in irreconcilable difference with what the poet seemed to say. The scene with Vibheeshana was one such point.

Vibheeshana's betrayal has to happen narratively, to upset the balance between the opposing forces. It also makes sense thematically, as Ravana's madness is so all-destroying it corrupts even the impeccable Vibheeshana into betraying his nature and acting against virtue. Vibheeshana is right to oppose Ravana; but the virtuous choice for him would be to die or to go into exile. Running straight to the enemy is very much the wrong choice. I see this as a tragic scene depicting the corruption of the last virtuous man in Lanka; Valmiki seems to see it as a celebration of Vibheeshana's virtue, and that I cannot agree with.

Eos coloured Lanka's skies red as blood, when Ravana rode in his chariot through his ruined City to his open court. A great amphitheatre, it stood on a ledge overlooking the Ocean below. Here Ravana's people had gathered, waiting for their King. Tears stung Ravana's eyes as he saw the destruction all around him, the ruined palaces, burned libraries, and still-smoking funeral pyres of his great City. But the people of Lanka were undefeated. They lined the streets, shouting "Victory!" as if at a festival. Ravana's heart swelled with pride as he saw his people rebuilding, undaunted by the attack. They loved him fiercely; and for a moment, Ravana was granted respite from his frenzy.

All Ravana's ministers and his brothers were assembled in the open court, the people of the city crowding around them at the edge. Even Kumbhakarna, the ancestor of the magnificent mountain trolls of far Hyperborea, who spent most of his time under enchantment as a sleeping mountain, had emerged from his deep slumber and come to Lanka.

Ravana sat under his white parasol of office, flanked by Kumbhakarna and Vibheeshana his brothers, his ministers arrayed on the steps below his feet. All were silent; only the waves could be heard, crashing onto the rocky shore below. "Men of Lanka," Ravana said, "our city has been brutally attacked, unprovoked and by a beast of the forest, not a man. My virtuous brother Vibheeshana prevailed upon me not to execute the one responsible, as he had been sent as a herald; and my brother was right to advise me, for now no blame attaches to us for any vengeance we may take, no gods or Furies will hunt us down. And so, my brothers,

councilors... what should I do? How shall I punish this false herald, and the even falser Prince who sent him? How shall I destroy this army of wild men, led by a wild god?"

But Ravana was to find no salvation in wise counsel; for his madness had begun to spread throughout his court, inspiring his ministers with a Bacchic thirst for blood. "Attack boldly!" they cried out. "Let their blood stain the forests of India for centuries to come! Avenge sevenfold each of our men slain. We are civilized; we live in the city. We have ships and chariots and weapons of bronze, and powerful magics wrought by our sages and sorcerers. These maenads are beasts, and their god is no more than an upstart Prince from the wild country.

"We are men; we do not bow to animals."

But Kumbhakarna the great mountain troll laughed; and the sound of his laughter was like the tread of Earth-Shaker himself. "You are fools, the lot of you," he said to the court, "and you, Ravana, my brother, are the greatest fool of them all. You are a scholar, Ravana, revered for your wisdom throughout all the world! I expected better of you than to deny the gods for the sake of a girl. You know the tales of Troy and of Thebes. It is clear that the frenzy of some god has taken possession of you, brother, or you would never commit such folly.

"Truly, you should be ashamed of yourself. With all your wisdom and all your power, how could you allow Bacchic madness to possess you, as though the great Ravana were no more than a Thracian shepherd boy frolicking on the hillside? Return to your senses, brother. You should never have taken that woman; it was a sacrilege, and you know it. As for the god Whom your dear councilors take pleasure in maligning, consult your library. Remind yourself of his terrible feats in other times and in other lands, and do not choose a war you cannot win. Listen to your elder brother, Ravana.

"But rest assured of one thing. I Kumbhakarna am no traitor to my own blood. I will stand by your side, brother, even if your cause is hopeless."

Now Vibheeshana, that virtuous philosopher, sat opposite Kumbhakarna. Here was a man who had devoted his life to wisdom and piety. While his intemperate brother went off on his endless wars of conquest, always Vibheeshana remained secure in his knowledge of the ancient scriptures, his understanding of the heavens and the earth, his firm conviction of his brother's might and wisdom.

But ever since the Arrow of Dionysos appeared on Lanka's bright horizon like a storm cloud at midday, Vibheeshana's certainties had all been shattered. No longer did the gods give their blessing to Lanka, in spite of all the sacrifices Vibheeshana brought them. No longer did Ravana listen to his counsel, seeking to meet any challenge armed with wisdom and strength. Instead, it seemed to Vibheeshana that the ancient scriptures mocked him; and he no longer recognized his brother. Stripped of the support of his gods and his wisdom, Vibheeshana was as a shipwrecked man, thrown by the waves this way and that. Heedless of his brother's anger, he sprang up into the centre of the court, raving almost as a Bacchant himself.

"You are wrong, you are all wrong, you miserable fools!" he cried out. "Ravana, you are wrong. Kumbhakarna, you are wrong for supporting him. Listen to me! You don't know Who it is that you oppose! You don't know what He will do to you if you incur His wrath. Give

back the woman, surrender today, and save yourselves! It is not yet too late for Lord Dionysos' mercy. But delay, and you will all end torn to pieces on the hillside, as at Thebes all those years ago.

“Ravana, I will never support you in a war against Lord Bromius.”

But the Arrow of Dionysos was stuck deep in Ravana's heart, and Vibheeshana's plea sent him into a frenzied rage. Only Kumbhakarna's mountainous strength restrained him from tearing Vibheeshana limb from limb, with his sword and with his teeth.

The court was in utter disarray. Women wailed, and cries of “Traitor!” went up on every side of the amphitheatre. But deep in Vibheeshana's heart a song began, a melody so sweet it soon filled his heart, his mind, his thoughts. He no longer heard the angry cries, no longer heard Ravana's grave threats, no longer saw the deep worry in Kumbhakarna's eyes. The song of Dionysos filled Vibheeshana's whole world, wiped away his tears, wiped away his thoughts.

All rakshasas can fly. And so Vibheeshana, smiling in ecstasy, his reason gone, forgot all his virtue and all his wisdom, abandoning his brothers, his City, and his people. Singing he went, flying across that blue Ocean to India, into the arms of the god Who stood there on the shore, waiting for him. And there Dionysos-Rama embraced him, making Vibheeshana the newest of His maenads. And Vibheeshana, helpless and destroyed, surrendered to the god's mercy; and divulged all Lanka's secrets.

Poseidon

Chapter Summary

Dionysos, as the Universal Spirit, threatens the destruction of the earth and the sea if Fate cannot be fulfilled. Deukalion's Flood, the westernmost version of the Mesopotamian Flood Story, happens in the background, and the land bridge to Lanka is built.

The arrivals of Hanuman and Vibheeshana had renewed the maenads' vigour. With hungry eyes they looked across the sea as though they could already see their destiny unfold. But Forest folk know little of seafaring; and they were not all sons of gods who could carry them through the air. Lakshman surveyed the maenad army, and despaired of a way to let them cross. "There is not enough wood in all the world," he said to Dionysos-Rama, "to build ships for such a host; and there is not a shipbuilder among them. We can cross only if Poseidon Abounding With Waves himself carries us."

But the Lord of the Sea was proud and arrogant. He churned his waves as a woman churns milk, raising up the sea in giant whirlpools, and the maenads recoiled from his wrath in terror. Dionysos-Rama approached the waves and cried out, "Lord of the Sea-Nymphs, I act on the impulse of Fate. Calm your waves, and let My maenads pass over you safely." But Poseidon gave no answer; he roared his waves even higher, refusing to let the maenads pass.

At this, Dionysos-Rama was overcome with fury: His eyes turned a fiery red, and His form grew tall as the sky. Knowing well the only force that could threaten a god, Dionysos-Rama, Who is Himself the Universal Spirit and thus higher than any god of the material Universe, summoned from within Himself the Fire that burns at the beginning and the end of the Kosmos. Gaia the Earth Mother trembled in fear as the skies darkened and the light of the sun went out. The maenads all lay prostrate at their god's feet in terror; but still Dionysos did not relent. The Fire took form as a bright golden arrow, which Dionysos took and fitted to His bow.

And an instant before all the seas of the world were engulfed in divine flame, Poseidon appeared: his long hair green with seaweed, his trident sparkling in the glow of the arrow, which was now the only light left in the Universe. "Universal Spirit," he begged of Dionysos, "relent, have mercy, or the earth and the sea shall be no more, and once again Chaos and Night shall reign!"

"You tarried in coming, brother," said Dionysos, "and My Fate lies across your Ocean. And if Fate cannot be fulfilled, this current Universe has reached its end and must be burned away like chaff."

“I promise safe passage to You and Your maenads, o Universal Spirit,” said Poseidon. “I beg of You, soften Your curse, limit Your Fire. Send Your arrow away from this place.”

And so Dionysos-Rama, Who could not recall His Fire once invoked, instead sent it westwards, far across foreign lands. It fell in the lands of Deukalion, where it rent the heavens and the earth and caused the wellsprings of the Underworld to gush forth their dark waters. And Poseidon had time to save only one man from that Great Flood.

With the Fire gone, the earth and the sea both calmed; and the sun shone in the sky once more. Dionysos-Rama returned to His human form and comforted the weeping Lakshman, who lay collapsed in terror at His feet. Poseidon, chastened, brought large stones to the surface of the water; and Nala son of Daedalos, an artificer of Kishkindha who was among that great army, built of these a bridge of floating rock, forgotten wonder of the ancient world.

And the maenads never feared the sea again; for they feared their god more than the tallest wave.

The Bacchae

Chapter Summary

These are the last three chapters of the main text, where Dionysia takes its bloodiest turn, passing from epic into horror. In these chapters I retell the events from Euripides' Bacchae, starting with the opening by Dionysos until the final, bloody orgy on Mount Cithaeron and the death of Pentheus/Ravana.

In this chapter, Dionysos gives his opening monologue from The Bacchae. He opens alone; telling us, his audience, who he is, and whom he is about to destroy. He is wild and inhuman: not a trace left of Rama the Prince of Ayodhya, only the god, a force of Nature, irresistible and terrifying as a hurricane, an earthquake.

The maenads are swept up into a frenzy of war, singing and dancing because they believe their cause is holy, a war of attrition in which no side is distinguishable anymore, both have lost their reason and can no longer stop the violence.

Valmiki, in your text you made war look so beautiful, so clear, so easy to see who is right and who is wrong. I think Euripides would have something to say to you about that.

Dancing did the maenads wash across their stony bridge.

Arriving on the far shore they finally saw Lanka's spires, its splendid colonnades, its majestic golden bulls. Casting their eyes upon the Labyrinth, sparkling in the rising sun, the maenads were struck with the City's beauty; but their love for their god and their fervour for Sita overcame their admiration. With loud cries of "Euoi!" and "Evius!" they descended upon the City; until an army vast as the wine-dark sea covered all the lands around Seven-Gated Lanka. Here they halted, unsure how to give battle to this great City. But Dionysos-Rama went out alone and stood before the walls of Lanka.

"Newly arrived in this land of Lanka, I am Dionysos, the Two-Natured, the Immortal Spirit, warlike and gentle, terrible and kind. I have changed my appearance from a god's to a man's, as I come to Ravana's isle and this City of Rakshasas.

"Once, I came from Lydia's fields abundant in gold, and Phrygia's. Persia's sunny uplands have I traversed, Bactria's walled cities and the bleak lands of the Medes, rich Arabia too, and all of India that lies by the salt sea and boasts fair-towered cities full of gold and full of men. Now to this City of Rakshasas have I come to make My godhead plain for mortal men to see, now that I have set those peoples dancing and instituted there My worship.

“Long ago, the Fates gave Kingship of Seven-Gated Lanka to Ravana, ten-headed for his wisdom, ten-hearted for his lust. But Ravana makes war on divinity by profaning My sacred Forests, polluting My sacred rites, and boldly taking Sita from My sacred grove.

“For this reason I have spurred him to madness, driven him in distraction from his palace. His wits have deserted him and he now has the field of battle for his home, a battle which he cannot win, for he fights against the gods.

“This City must learn its lesson, however reluctantly, that it lacks the blessing of Goodness and Truth. So come, My band of maenads who waited for Me an Age of the Universe and never broke your faith: rouse your kettledrums, take up your thyrsi, dance around the palace of Ravana so all his citizens may see.”

With that call, the sound of drums, pipes, and ecstatic song filled the air as the army of maenads began the celebration of their rite. But the City was well defended. Wave after wave of rakshasa warriors came for the maenads, all armed with bronze and star-metal and terrible, dark magics that rained fire from the sky. Soon, their arrows and their javelins blotted out the sun.

But neither bronze nor fire did the maenads any harm. Blessed with the god’s strength, the maenads effortlessly destroyed the armies of Lanka, inflicting grave wounds with a swing of the thyrsus. And swing they did, in song and in ecstasy, unaware that they were in a battle at all, not a dance.

Lanka had become a winepress in which rakshasa blood was treaded like the finest wine, flowing in divine abundance across the fields, across the gardens, Lanka’s emerald turning a glistening ruby. And still the maenads felt no war, no pain; only joy, and dance, and music. The rakshasas, being trolls of the hills and mountains gave in to their wild natures and tore the maenads with their teeth, gulping down their flesh and blood like the Titans of old; and the maenads in their Bacchic frenzy did the same.

And amidst the dance upon the field of blood stood Dionysos-Rama, smiling kindly from among the carnage of that great Bacchic revel in which all sides were drunk on blood as on the sweetest wine, all by His will, through His inspiration. He called out to Ravana, high upon a balcony of his Labyrinthine House, with open arms and the gentlest, kindest voice. “My dear friend, it is still possible for us to settle this matter sensibly. No need for further violence!”

But Ravana from atop his spire cried out, “I know You! You are trying to trick me!” And there was wildness in his eyes and terror in his broken voice, for the Arrow of Dionysos had completed its work upon Ravana’s heart and had driven out his reason. Frenzied, wild, and powerless, the once-wise Lord of Lanka stared at his god.

“What trick would that be,” said Dionysos-Rama kindly, “My trying to save you? I do care for you, Ravana of Lanka. Stop this, accept My offer of peace which I extend to you with open arms and open heart, and your City shall prosper. I can even restore to life all those you have lost: your brothers, your sons.”

But it was futile. Crazed by Bacchic madness and driven by the Fates, a man possessed, Ravana refused; pulled irresistibly towards his destruction, his death drawing him as the fisherman draws in his nets.

“Then you shall learn, o Ravana, that I Dionysos am a god by turns most gentle to mortals, and most terrible.”

And Dionysos-Rama, ever gracious, ever kind, never ceased to smile; never stopped inviting Ravana into His arms and into His heart.

Ravana and Sita

Chapter Summary

These are the last three chapters of the main text, where Dionysia takes its bloodiest turn, passing from epic into horror. In these chapters I retell the events from Euripides' *Bacchae*, starting with the opening by Dionysos until the final, bloody orgy on Mount Cithaeron and the death of Pentheus/Ravana.

In this chapter, Ravana is finally broken the way Pentheus is. One by one, all his loved ones fall away, until he is left all alone. Several duels take place in the style of a Greek *aristeia*, a hero's moment of highest excellence in battle: Angada and Kumbhakarna, and Lakshman and Indrajit.

Even Sita becomes inaccessible to Ravana, as she reveals to him she is his daughter following a South Indian tradition of the Ramayana. The final line is a quote from Sophocles' *Oedipus The King*, spoken by Oedipus when he discovers his own true identity, and that of Jocasta.

Day and night the battle raged on, for inspired by the power of Dionysos neither the maenads nor the rakshasas ever slept. Instead all danced in His rite, possessed by His mystery. On this battlefield not even the gods intervened; not even Ares or grey-eyed Athene picked out their favourites. For this was a battle greater than that of Troy. Only Dionysos-Rama stood there, at the heart of the fighting: still smiling, still gentle, still offering peace if Ravana would only accept Him, only acknowledge Him, only receive His blessing.

One by one Ravana's generals fell to the maenads in that churning sea of blood and ecstasy. Akampana, Prahastha, Dhrumraksha, all were slain. Ravana sat alone and downcast in his palace. His former splendour gone, his spirit shattered by the frenzy of Dionysos, Ravana sat forlornly on the Bull Throne of Lanka.

But Ravana was much beloved still. His elder brother, the great Kumbhakarna, big and strong as a mountain, came to him. Dressed in white silks he was, as an initiate of the Mysteries, bedecked in blood-red garnet and gold. "My brother," said Kumbhakarna, "what has come over you? What strange power of Bacchus has done this to my Ravana, who was once so powerful, so wise? Set your heart at ease, brother. God He may be, and foolish it may have been for you to oppose Him; but I promised you I would not desert you, and anyone who does to my brother as Rama has done to you will pay, whether he be god or man."

Ravana cried out in anguish and embraced his brother again and again, reluctant to release him. But Kumbhakarna, reasonable and serene, unaffected by the Bacchic frenzy, calmed Ravana; and so that great rakshasa armed himself and took the field against a Power before which he could not stand.

Whole choruses of fighting maenads fell before Kumbhakarna like wheat before the scythe. At last, the rakshasa giant stood in his chariot before Dionysos-Rama. "Lord Bromius," he said, "I know Who You are. My brother is wrong to oppose You; but You are a god also of justice and mercy. I must defend my brother. So do battle with me, o Universal Spirit, and accept my life in Ravana's stead."

But Dionysos-Rama looked up at Kumbhakarna with pure love in His eyes, and said, "Your faithfulness to your brother commends you, Kumbhakarna. But the Fates rule the affairs of both gods and men, and Ravana's Thread was cut long ago. Ravana must die, faithful one, so that he may finally be free: free from rebirth, free from suffering. Today I deliver Ravana from his pain; and you likewise."

And with those words from his god, Angada son of Vali, given strength to wield a tree in each hand like dual thyrsi wrapped in ivy, crushed Kumbhakarna where he stood, a mountain vanquished by forest. And far away in the Hyperborean Sea, Katla has wept tears of fire ever since.

Indrajit Ravana's son was the only one left to bring his father news of Kumbhakarna's death. Ravana collapsed in a faint when he heard it; and when he was revived, his son said to him, "Father, the gods have turned against us. But do not lose hope! For long ago, another great King on another island found himself sorely beset by Earth-Shaker's wrath.

"His own god gone, all seemed lost to King Minos, whose island Kingdom was home to Daedalos' First Labyrinth as we are to his Second. But Minos' son went down to the seashore in the midst of Earth-Shaker's fire that rained down from the sky, and he brought there a sacrifice that finally appeased the god.

"You will not allow me to return Sita to her god. So, I shall go down to the seashore, as in the days of Minos, and win back the favour of the many gods against this One."

And so Indrajit, greatest of Lanka's warriors save only Ravana himself, Indrajit of whom Zeus himself went in fear, rode out onto the battlefield. With a magical weapon he bound and captured a dancing maenad, and carried her away senseless in his chariot. The maenads saw only a flash of lightning rush by, as Indrajit hurried to the cave on the eastern shore in which stood Lanka's most secret altar. For this was to be a fire sacrifice; but of no ordinary kind.

But Lakshman, standing beside his divine brother, had seen Indrajit and followed him in secret. He came to the cave mouth and saw Indrajit, knife raised above the weeping maenad bound to the crude stone altar, invoking Poseidon Earth-Shaker. "Son of Ravana!" Lakshman cried out. "You have learned well from your Cretan predecessor. But you have forgotten the end of his story; forgotten the reason why Theseus sailed home with black sails that day.

"How can your gods save you, Indrajit, if you have chosen war with Lord Dionysos, have set yourself against the Universal Spirit, beyond the pale of justice and good?"

And before Indrajit was able to slaughter his victim, a crescent-tipped arrow from Lakshman's quiver like a scythe cut him down. His head rolled off and away; and Indrajit's own blood flowed across his altar, no god coming to Lanka's rescue, as none had come to Crete's.

Within the walls of his Labyrinth, Ravana hid himself. Others built pyres for Indrajit and Kumbhakarna; others rallied themselves in desperation, a last attempt to defend their City. Ravana, once known for his wisdom, his love for his people, his devotion to his gods, ran wild like a Bacchant through the many rooms of his deserted Labyrinth.

He knew only Sita, all else forgotten, wiped from his mind by Dionysos' frenzy: Ravana lived Sita, breathed Sita, saw only her face, blind to the world around him. His City lost, his sons and his brothers all dead, Ravana sought Sita, the one remaining light in his life, and found her in the ashoka grove, newly replanted.

Sita sat alone on a patch of grass, a lotus pond beside her reflecting the starry sky above. She sat and wept: for Ayodhya, for Lanka, for Kishkindha, for all the blood that flowed for her sake, the Bacchic frenzy she was born to bring into the world. But when Ravana fell before her, grasping her knees like a suppliant, he saw her smiling through her tears. For Sita knew that finally the moment was at hand for Dionysos her god, Lord of the Universe, to be glorified; that finally the time of the Dionysia had come, when the Universal Spirit would free them all from suffering.

"Sita," said Ravana in a broken voice scarcely more than a whisper, "my City is gone and my people are ashes. All those I loved besides you are dead. And I would burn them all again, for your sake. Sita, I have tried to buy your love; I have tried to seduce you; I have tried to threaten you. But you are too pure to yield to such base means.

"You have won, Sita. I am nothing. I have nothing left to entice you with, no power left to threaten. So be gracious in your victory, o Goddess, and accept me for mercy's sake alone. Please be mine, please love me; all of Lanka is worth burning for even one day of your love. Love me, or I shall die."

But Sita merely shook her head and, weeping, said to Ravana, "I cannot do as you ask; not even if there were no Rama, not even for all the mercy of heaven. You do not know what it is you ask for.

"Listen," she continued, "listen to the word of Fate. Once, long ago, Mandodari your chief wife left you for her father's house. And after many months, she came back; and all was as before. But Mandodari never told you what she did while away from your house. She never told you how she cut the throats of her escort, and escaped into the forest. She never told you how she wandered alone for months, before coming to a city on the edge of a great jungle. She never told you of the child she bore and exposed, left to die in a furrow in the earth.

"Mandodari had a daughter by you, Ravana of Lanka; a daughter with golden skin that shone in the starlight, a daughter whom she left in a furrow in the earth for Janaka of Mithila to find, a living offering to Hera. The goddess was kind to the girl-child, and made her live and prosper. And on this day, Ravana, she sits before you."

Ravana gave her no answer. He lay at her feet, senseless as if dead. How dreadful the knowledge of the truth can be, when there is no help in truth.

Dionysia

Chapter Summary

These are the last three chapters of the main text, where Dionysia takes its bloodiest turn, passing from epic into horror. In these chapters I retell the events from Euripides' *Bacchae*, starting with the opening by Dionysos until the final, bloody orgy on Mount Cithaeron and the death of Pentheus/Ravana.

In this chapter, Ravana finally faces Dionysos, alone, maddened, and with no support left, just like Pentheus up in his tree at Mount Cithaeron.

In ancient performances of *The Bacchae*, Dionysos was said to have worn a smiling mask throughout, showing gentleness and love even as the carnage unfolds. This struck me as the most horrifying part of all of *The Bacchae*, and I have tried to replicate it in *Dionysia*.

Ramesh Menon, whom I have used as a source, ends his rendition of the *Ramayana* Book VI with a prayer in Sanskrit. I follow his example and end with an invocation in Greek: Glory to Dionysos, Glory to the Lord of the Universe.

At last, nothing stood any longer between Ravana and his Fate. Helios rose brightly over a deserted Labyrinth in a crisp, perfect morning. Silence now reigned over Lanka, for there was no one left to light fires in the City's temples, no poets left to sing, no men left to speak. Even Sita, who had sat in Ravana's ashoka grove till the very end, had gone.

Slowly, dazed, no longer himself but a man possessed, Ravana moved through room after room of his majestic Cretan House, making as though by instinct for his armoury. His footsteps resounded through those fair-columned halls, for the Labyrinth was unused to emptiness and had turned hollow, cavernous. Ravana now was finally become the perfect postulant to the Mysteries, the perfect receptacle of Dionysos' Light. All that he had once been wiped away, he saw nothing but the god's face, the benevolent face of Dionysos smiling at him in love.

Deeply, fatally drawn to that face he was – even Sita forgotten now, no intermediary needed anymore between Ravana and his deliverance. But a last flickering remnant of Ravana's former pride remained; and it would not let him surrender without battle.

And so it was that Ravana rode out from his fallen City in splendid bronzen scale armour and a splendid golden chariot, decked all over with lapis and carnelian. A churning sea of blood met him beyond the City walls, choruses of maddened maenads dancing through it all in ecstasy; but Ravana saw nothing, heard nothing, but Dionysos' gentle call. So fierce and exultant was the look in Ravana's eyes that the maenads made way for him in terror and

admiration. Dionysos-Rama stood there in the midst of the carnage, His chariot wound round with ivy, alone. He smiled at Ravana with genuine warmth, and held out a hand in invitation.

And the last flicker of pride was wiped clean from Ravana's heart; so that he took his god's hand without protest, understanding at last all his suffering across all his many, many lives, and the freedom which Dionysos offers to all mortals. And Dionysos, still smiling, took up the sacred labrys in His other hand; and in a single stroke severed all ten of Ravana's heads.

Gently, lovingly, the Universal Spirit led Ravana's shade down to Hades, down to deliverance from his pain and his enslavement to the wheel of rebirth, down to bliss.

KHAIRE DIONYSE! KHAIRE HO TOU KOSMOU BASILEU!

Thebes Stands Empty

Chapter Summary

The aftermath of the battle sees the funeral games for Ravana and the coronation of Vibheeshana celebrated as a single Dionysia, a great festival of the god. Mandodari gives a funeral ode for her husband using Kadmos' lines from *The Bacchae*, then goes into exile like Agave.

Silence fell in a great hush across the battlefield at Ravana's death. Rakshasas and maenads both let fall their weapons, staring in wonder at one another, at Dionysos-Rama, at the risen sun. The Mystery was over, the spell broken, the music ceased. The time had come for revelers to go home.

Then a woman came forth from Lanka's gates, a great Lady, clearly a Queen. All made way as Mandodari, Queen of Lanka, came to claim her husband's corpse.

"O house that once in earlier days was counted happy by all men, how I grieve for you," she said. "Ravana is dead, grandson of Pulastya, High King of the Labyrinth."

The maenads, curious now, gathered round Mandodari as she lay across Ravana's corpse. One exclaimed, "O Bromius, my Lord, You are shown to be a mighty god!"

"What do you mean?" asked Mandodari, lifting her tear-stained face, her eyes a burning flame. "Do you take pleasure in our misfortune, enemies though we may be? Are your hearts so hardened, your souls so seared, that you can feel no compassion for my grief?"

But the maenad broke into song,

"A foreigner am I, and in barbaric strains

I hail my god – no more

do I cower in fear of chains!"

"Defeated and diminished we may be," said Mandodari, "yet do you think Lanka so lacking in power and allies that you will not be punished for this?"

"Dionysos-Rama, not Lanka, has power over me!"

"I can sympathize with you, initiate," said Mandodari, "but to rejoice in the doing of a foul deed – there is no honour in that. O, how He has destroyed us, the god, the Universal Spirit, how He has set us free in the only way He knows – justly, perhaps, but excessively. O Ravana

my husband, it would have been better had you submitted. Your pride might have been wounded; but you would not have been taken from me so cruelly.

"To be virtuous in one's life and show reverence to the gods is the noblest course; it is also, I think, the wisest."

Mandodari did not keen or wail, nor did she tear her hair and face with her hands. Instead in quiet dignity she mourned her husband. Sugriva, old Satyr, was moved by the sight and said, "Your lot is painful in my eyes, o Queen; but Ravana has the justice he deserved, the deliverance he needed, the unification with the Ultimate which all us mortals have desired since the ashes of the Titans gave us life.

"Do not weep for your husband, Lady. He has been granted deliverance from suffering."

"You are right," answered Mandodari, "it is not Ravana who suffers; it is I. I must go into exile, where foul Lanka may not see me, nor I Lanka; I must go to a place where no lyre sounds, no thyrsus may stir my memory. Where am I to turn, banished from my country?"

And with those words, Mandodari, Queen of Lanka, left that battlefield outside her City; and she was seen no more.

Next Sita, her work done, ran from Lanka's gates into Dionysos' waiting arms. Her eyes filled with tears, fearing Dionysos but also loving Him still, Sita embraced her divine husband and Lakshman His brother.

But though the battle was won, the god's purpose was not yet fulfilled. For Vibheeshana Ravana's brother, who had been among the maenads overcome by the god's madness, now threw himself across his brother's body and wept, refusing to let go.

Dionysos-Rama lifted him up and said, "Vibheeshana, you are wise. You know that what happened here was part of the Mystery: that Ravana has finally found the Ultimate which he sought, in knowledge, in power, in Sita. Lanka still survives, and your people need a King. Rule them for My sake, and for your brother's."

So saying, He took Vibheeshana by the hand and placed him on the Bull Throne of Lanka, a new Minos for a new Labyrinth. Then Dionysos, Who is Lord also of the Underworld, called back from Hades' gates all the shades of all the maenads who had fallen in that battle. And as their flesh returned to life, their blood spilled upon the field turned to the finest wine; so that a true Dionysia served the still-weeping Vibheeshana as coronation feast.

The women and children of Lanka left their homes and their gates and joined in the celebration of their new King; and a great many poets, heralds, and musicians came onto the fields and streets of Lanka to perform in honour of Ravana and of Dionysos-Rama, his god and his Liberator. In the end, even Vibheeshana drank, and forgot his grief.

Seven days and seven nights did Ravana's funeral games last. And when the days and nights were up, Dionysos and His maenads went dancing back to the Ocean, out of the Mystery, back to the world.

Katabasis

Chapter Summary

The proper ending to any Dionysos story is a descent to the Underworld (Greek katabasis), which carries the promise of the god's return.

In this final chapter, Dionysia returns to its theme from Chapter 1: the incarnated Dionysos, ruling as a mortal King, descends to the Underworld, leaving His followers to scatter across India awaiting His return.

This chapter also includes the earliest source I know for the story of Snow White and the Huntsman, in a scene I found in a footnote to Book VII. In that note, Ramesh Menon tells of a South Indian tradition which has Rama order Lakshman to kill Sita and bring back proof that he has; Lakshman, distraught, brings home the ear of a deer instead. Rama, like the Witch Queen in Snow White, never looks, and believes Sita to be dead.

Many glorious years did Dionysos-Rama and His maenads live upon the earth, after the god returned in triumph to Ayodhya His city and to Bharata His brother. Rama found his brothers faithful, his mothers contrite and devoted; and he assumed the Kingship of Ayodhya amidst cries of victory, his loving wife Sita by his side.

But death and decay come even to Arcadia. His mission done, the Great Spirit of Dionysos left Rama in time; so that he was human once more, mortal and limited as he had not been since many years.

And so Rama ruled Ayodhya as any mortal King rules a city. As the years went by, and the city grew, he became ever more distant, ever more regal; until the man who as a youth had known his every citizen by name no longer spoke to them, no longer mixed with his people. Instead he sat in his palace, a magnificent structure of divine symmetries, filled with gold and precious stone, and listened to bards and poets declare his praises in song.

One such evening, Rama sat on a golden lotus throne, Sita and Lakshman by his side, and asked the poets, "You traveling bards hear many rumours. Tell me, what do the people of my city say of me?"

But with the Spirit of the god had gone Rama's divine mercy and his capacity for deliverance; so that those around him now only feared his power and his wrath. The poets all paled in terror; and none dared answer, nor did even Lakshman or Sita venture to speak.

Finally one bard, casting a glance at Sita for support, said, "My Lord, your people are safe and prosperous. They remember well your strength, how you waged war upon the great City of Lanka and destroyed its King, whom all men thought invincible. They have no cause for complaint.

"And yet... I have heard murmurs in the streets, my Lord, in the alleys and on the riverbanks. I have heard women say that none of their kind could keep her virtue against Ravana, that his temptation was too strong. I have heard them doubt your Queen's loyalty, o King; and I have heard men doubt your purity of heart, for keeping her in your house."

Now Rama had loved Sita dearer than his own life; so that at first, he dismissed all those poets without payment and forbade them to ever return to Ayodhya on pain of death. But the divine Spirit had withdrawn, and Sita had long since fulfilled her purpose. Though he loved her still, she no longer possessed the frenzied allure to Rama's mind that once she had done; and so, as the days went by, doubt began to grow in Rama's heart, a battle between his love for his wife and his love for his city.

Deeper and deeper did this doubt eat at the King's spirit. Finally he could bear it no longer and called Lakshman his brother into his presence. "You have heard what the people say about me," Rama said. "Lakshman, your loyalty is beyond question. You remained steadfast at my side, through our exile in the Forest, through the frenzy of the god, through our battle against Lanka.

"I now call upon your loyalty yet again. I cannot keep both Sita and my throne. And though I do not know whether Sita has truly been unfaithful, the mere possibility eats at my heart. I cannot bear to keep her any longer. Lakshman, what I am about to ask you will sound excessive; but such is the way of Kings, and you must obey me. Do this: take Sita in your chariot, drive her to the edge of the Forest in which we dwelt for fourteen years, and there kill her. As proof that she is truly dead, bring me back her heart."

Lakshman was struck with astonishment at his royal brother's words, but he could not refuse Rama. And so, the dawn of the following day saw Lakshman and Sita ride out, away from the city as pilgrims go. But no man was there to look more closely; no man or woman saw the tears in Lakshman's eyes, the look of bitter resolve in Sita's.

Rivers they crossed, and fields and marshes, all in total silence; each understanding what was happening but unwilling to speak it aloud. When they reached the edge of the dark Forest, forever changed now, never the same, Lakshman dismounted and drew his sword. "Sister, forgive me," he said to Sita, "your virtue must have drawn the envy of the gods, for treacherous voices are raised against you in the city and even your husband has been swayed. He sent me here to end your life; but I cannot bring myself to raise my sword against you."

But Sita remained serene throughout; and now she regarded Lakshman as the Sphinx had done Oedipus. "I know well my husband's heart," she said. "I know how the power of the god sustained him; how he weakened, wilted, once the oracles of Dionysos left his dreams. I know how he sits in his palace, a stranger to himself, ruling his people as a distant tyrant. I know that the kind youth I married was lost the day he set foot in this Forest.

"I know also that you alone remain loyal. Therefore, listen to my words. Kill a deer here in the woods, cut off its ear, and skin it so that the flesh and the blood are exposed. Then cut from my dress a square of silk, and wrap the ear in it. Take it back to Rama and tell him I am dead. He will not open it."

And so Lakshman, weeping, did as Sita told him; and he returned to his brother, who, satisfied, did not ask him again. But Sita went off into the Forest and found an empty ashram. Here she lived, sustained by Hera who pitied her fate; and here she bore Rama twin sons, unknown by any save the goddess herself.

Thus did Rama continue to rule his city, alone this time, and bitter, for love had gone from his life. But the Spirit of Dionysos had not altogether abandoned him. One day, an old mystic came to Ayodhya; he came from the wild forest, dressed in fawnskins, the sound of pipes preceding him in the strains of a Phrygian song.

His arrival stirred the old memory of the god within Rama's heart; and the King asked to see him instantly. "What brings you to my city, o master?" Rama asked him.

"I have come, o King," said the sage, "to inform you of your Fate. You are the Lord Dionysos incarnated upon the earth; but your mission is long since complete, and so the Spirit has withdrawn itself and returned to the divine realms. My Lord, I have seen the Moirai at work upon the Thread of your life, and I know you have as well. Why do you tarry? It is time for Dionysos to return to the Underworld once more, so that from the buried seed next year's wheat may grow."

And so the next day at dawn, Rama and Lakshman went down to the river side by side as their people watched in astonishment. Great whirlpools rose up in that sparkling blue water as though in anticipation. Lakshman was first to enter; ever devoted, he walked into the river until its waters covered him completely, and he was seen no more.

His brother followed him into that stream of Hades; and as the waters covered Rama's body, the river erupted in a blinding light like the fires of Helios' horses. And Dionysos, now fully divine, no longer clinging to mortal flesh, bright and burning and comforting and not of this world, appeared from the light to His stricken followers one last time.

The god vanished, and the river returned to its regular form, light and fire gone. The people of Ayodhya worshipped at the riverbank; and a great many of them went down into the river themselves, following their god to his palace in the Underworld. Others took up their burdens and their wives and children and went away from that holy place, spreading across the lands of India as once the maenads had done.

The City of Ayodhya has been sacred to Dionysos ever since. Still today it stands, a memorial to the greatest Dionysia ever celebrated upon the earth.

KHAIRE DIONYSE

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